

Glossary

Bakazi - Supernatural beings with magic powers used to protect and enhance nature.

Blue stone - Rare quartz that protects the Bakazi. Also known as Llanite.

Cambion - Offspring of an Incubus and a human.

Enforcer demon - Cambion mercenary who is primarily paid to collect on demon deals and contracts.

Incubus - High level demon whose plan it is to harvest Bakazi DNA to create a more powerful being.

Kipeyo - Butterfly

Seeker - Bakazi who can see the future.

Siliana - Bakazi who can hear other thoughts and sometimes control them.

Spawn - Offspring of Cambion or Incubus and Bakazi.

Tari - Bakazi who have the power to heal.

Wayward - Bakazi who walked away from or have no knowledge of magical heritage.

Chapter One

Falling to her death is not the way Autumn thought her life would end. But here she is falling face first to the earth with no parachute. As he got closer to her final resting place, she started to recognize the scene below. The Llano River. The thick oak and cedar trees and crescent shaped rock formation signaled a familiar place. She didn't want to die here.

Ask and you shall receive, she guessed. In a second, Autumn realized her swift plunge had slowed.

She floated like a dandelion on the breeze until she ended up hovering over the water. Something was there moving just below the surface. Make that someone.

The details of the person's face were hard to see through the water. Long dark hair floated around like a graceful shadow as she looked all around. The woman's outstretched arms frantically searched for something. A way out? The woman paused as she noticed Autumn hovering above the surface. She stopped struggling to stare at Autumn through the murky water as if seeing a long-lost friend. A hand stretched out and Autumn realize the mysterious woman was reaching for her.

As terrified as she was it would be cruel to leave her to a watery grave. She stretched her arm out toward the woman. The cloudy water started to clear just as her fingertips broke the surface. Then as if an alarm had been tripped a loud beeping started.

Autumn gasped and coughed as she sat up. She was in her bed. In her room. Safe. The digital clock on her dresser read 8:16.

"Another crazy dream. At least I didn't oversleep today."

Knock Knock Knock

"Are you up?" said a familiar voice from the opposite side of Autumn's closed bedroom door.

"Uh Um Yeah. I'll be out in a minute." Autumn replied while grasping the ring that hung around her neck. Something she often did when she was scared or uneasy. And these weird dreams always left a knot in her stomach.

"Are you ok?"

Autumn took a deep calming breath before replying. Kamara could always tell when something was bothering her and Autumn wasn't ready to share the details of her crazy dreams.

"Kam I'm fine. Not everyone can be like you in the mornings Miss. Sunshine.

"Fine" Kamara laughed "But muffins are fresh out of the oven, and I need a taste tester."

"Mmmm." Ok but give me a few minutes to get ready for work first." Said Autumn "I'm like 80 percent sure Allen is gonna fire me if I'm late again.

"He's not gonna fire you. Those kids adore you."

"And I adore them which is why I don't want to get fired." Autumn responded hopping out of bed and heading for the bathroom down the hall.

Kamara was attempting to perfect her cranberry orange flavored muffins this week.

Kamara is an amazing cook, so Autumn had no problem being the taste tester.

Twenty minutes later Autumn sat across the table from her best friend. The house that they shared was small, but it did include a breakfast nook with a bay window overlooking the front yard.

"So, what do think?" Kamara asked. "More cranberries or less cranberries?"

"It's perfect. I think these are my new favorite muffins.

"You say that about all my food."

"Well, I mean it every time. You're a genius in the kitchen. Your food speaks to my soul. Waffle House does not deserve you" Autumn said absently rubbing the back of her neck.

"How's your head?" Kam asked.

"Oh, much better." Autumn replied in what she hoped was a convincing tone.

Autumn over heated about two weeks ago while doing some yard work and passed out in the front yard. Thankfully Kamara had left work early and found her near the front steps. When Autumn woke up someone was playing a cymbal inside her head and shining a police search light in her eyes. She quickly realized that she had hit her head when she fell. Kam insisted on taking her to the hospital but that was a no go. Autumn would rather crawl over hot coals than go to a hospital. The compromise was Kamara making a terrible herbal remedy. It smelled like sweaty onions and old potatoes, but it did the trick. Autumn felt great. The only lingering affects seemed to be these strange dreams and ringing in her ears, but she didn't dare mention either to

Kam for fear of another herbal fix.

"I better get going." Autumn said rising from her seat and grabbing muffin for the road. She tilted the cup back to finish her orange juice before taking the empty vessel to the sink.

"Don't forget about Lavender tonight, Autumn."

But Autumn was already out the door and pretended not to hear the invitation. She was not the night owl that Kam was, and she really didn't want to get all dressed up to go to the club.

She took another bite of her muffin, hopped in her blue Honda hatchback and headed off to work. The homemade breakfast confection perfumed the cabin. The smell of oranges always made her feel happy. But anything that Kamara cooked had that effect.

Jack gazed out from the top of the hill at sunrise. He knew what he would see. The same canopy of trees. The same lazy river winding its way through the back of the twelve-acre property. This was always the reward for his morning run and for getting out of bed before dawn. This view reminded him of why he worked so hard to be the best at his job. Undisturbed nature and safety for his queen and his people, the

Bakazi. Most of the lore labeled the Bakazi as fairies or fae but most of the lore was wrong. The Bakazi were the Bakazi period. His people may have some of the same powers as the fae but they were not the same beings. They didn't live under toadstools or fly around on butterfly wings. And they weren't all goodness and light especially ones like Jack.

The Bakazi half of him was strong and sure but that was only half. Jack had been fighting the temptations of his other half for years but in the past few weeks something had changed. That part of him was trying to claw and chew its way out and no matter what Jack did he knew a change was inevitable. He just needed time alone to think of a way to handle this. Peace and quiet.

"Hey Jack"

Well, there goes my quite Jack thought.

"Fuck. I don't need a run partner or a babysitter, Carver" Jack said walking in the opposite direction "I'm heading down for a swim. Fuck off."

"I know you asked for space, but the queen has requested an audience." Carver replied.

That was the one thing guaranteed to stop Jack's forward momentum.

"When?" Jack asked.

"Now."

"Alright. Jack said sparing a glance at Carver. "Has the Squad been informed?"

"No." said Carver. "You don't understand. The queen requested a private audience with you."

Shit." Jack said through clenched teeth.

And there went his peace.

The queen had asked for a private meeting with him. Had she learned about his problem? Getting black out intoxicated was not such a great idea. Especially when your whole reason for being was to stay alert and protect those in your care. The constant battle in his mind made it hard to sleep. With sleep came the nightmares that depicted exactly what would happen if he gave in. At least if he drank enough, he could pass out and slip into nothingness. But the nothingness never lasted, and he was right back to the war within.

When they arrived at the Palace courtyard both Carver and Jack headed to south lawn. The palace stood on the North lawn. It had been built over 100 years ago to house the rulers of the race when they escaped The Continent.

On the south lawn just behind a grove of trees stood a two-story carriage house inhabited by The Squad. The Squad was a group of males who protected their race. A race that was not as close knit as they used to be. Some Bakazi were not even aware of their magical heritage now. The Squad could trace their lines back for over one hundred years. Unfortunately, you could not choose your genetic lineage and the bloodlines of the entire Squad had been...tainted. Each and every male of the Squad had pledged to lay down their lives for their queen without question or hesitation.

After a quick shower, Jack headed to meet with Queen Rayvn who had reluctantly ascended to the throne after her mother's death. The queen was waiting in the oversized chair near a window. She was wearing a long casual dress that hid any trace of the form beneath. Feet tucked up underneath herself fidgeting with the rings on her hands. She somehow always managed to make herself look even smaller than her already small frame. Jack was constantly intrigued by the fact that someone with so much power could seem almost painfully uncomfortable in her station. As if she didn't belong.

"Hello my queen"

"Hi. It's very nice to see you this morning Jack" the queen replied.

She then looked to the tall figure standing near a wall of books on the opposite side of the room.

"Please excuse us father" she said.

The dowager king bowed his head out of respect for his daughter before submitting to her request.

"Good day King Silas." Jack said.

King Silas did not respond or acknowledge Jack as he walked past him to the door.

The treatment was nothing new, but it still stung.

Jack fell silent not knowing what to say next. The queen broke the silence.

"My father is old fashioned. I apologize for his behavior."

"There is no need for an apology my queen."

Rayvn opened her mouth as if to argue her point but closed it again and looked down at her still fidgeting hands.

"I asked you to come here because I need your help."

"Of course, my queen" Anything that you request is law."

The queen visibly flinched at this.

"I apologize Queen Ravyn. I did not mean to -"

"Please". she replied looking at his face. "There is no need for you to apologize Jack.

As I said I need your help with something. I need you to retrieve a Wayward."

"She lives in the Hill Country as a human. This Wayward is unaware of her heritage.

Her name is Autumn, and she must be safely and quietly delivered to me."

The queen took a breath and turn away to gaze out of the window. The sun shone in creating an auburn halo around her coils of dark hair. Funny how Jack had never noticed this before. He had always assumed that the queen had been named for her dark black hair but in reality, her hair was a deep dark red.

"May I ask my queen what is this Wayward's crime?"

"She is not a danger to the race. She needs our protection."

The queen stuck a hand into a pocket on her dress and pulled out piece of paper.

"I was visited by the elder Vervina about two weeks ago. She had a vision of this young Wayward. The queen said revealing a printed black and white photo of a young woman. She was kneeling next to a small boy with a toy truck in her hand. A fire truck. The boy was beaming as he admired what was obviously a new toy. And though only the Fae's profile was visible, Jack could see that she was beaming right back at the little boy. For a moment Jack felt his heart fall out of rhythm. Probably from the display of caring. Jack had seen far to little of that type of caring in his own life.

"Forgive me Queen Ravyn," Jack said "but are you positive that I am the one that you wish to send. I don't know a lot about the young ones."

"Young ones?"

"Yes," said Jack. "If this Autumn has a child perhaps someone else would have an easier time interacting with them. Bonding with the child would be an excellent way to gain the trust of this Wayward. May I suggest you send Lucky. He is like a large child."

"Oh. No Jack. You misunderstand. This child does not belong to Autumn. She works at an orphanage called Rainbow House in the Hill Country."

"This boy is an orphan?"

"Yes" Queen Rayvn said quietly.

Orphans were a sore subject in the Bakazi community.

"We were able to use clues from Vervina's vision to locate the Wayward. This photo is from a news article about a 6 months ago at a Holiday toy drive at the Rainbow Valley orphanage."

Jack eyed the photo again and again his heart skipped a beat.

"May I ask my queen, what vision of this Wayward did Vervina see?"

"I can only tell you that she is important for the future of our race."

Chapter Two

Like most afternoons Autumn said goodbye to her kids with secret handshakes or hugs before heading to log out of her computer, grab her things and headed home. She couldn't pass the bowl on the entry table without grabbing a sweet treat. Autumn popped a kiwi flavored Hi-Chew into her mouth and headed out into the warm evening air. Other parts of the country were still cool in the spring but in Central Texas the weather was a bit warmer. That was fine with Autumn. She loved this time of year. It felt like the world was waking up from a long hibernation.

When she was little, she planted a vegetable garden with her mom every year. They would plant cucumbers, collard greens, bell peppers and tomatoes. Autumn couldn't wait to see the first sign of life poke its green head out of the soil every spring. These memories never failed to make her smile. They also reminded her of how much she missed her mom.

As usual Autumn had to parked across the street about a half a block away from Rainbow House in front of The Church of Fellowship and Mercy or CFM for short. There were always people coming and going from the building. The church was very involved with the community including Rainbow House. In fact, she had first met Reverend Adams and Reverend Mikael's at the Holiday fund raiser for Rainbow House. The two men had insisted that she use the brightly lit church parking lot. Autumn usually stayed late and quickly accepted the offer. A girl can't be too careful. Especially after dark.

CFM reached out to the press to draw more attention to the needs at the orphanage. And man did it work. Reverend Adams and Reverend Mikael's provided cookies for the holiday bake sale. Between the press and the bake sale Rainbow House was

able to raise more than enough money to get blankets and warm clothes for all the children. Not to mention the anonymous donor who claimed they had seen the story on the news and wanted to brighten the holidays for the children. That extremely generous donation bought gifts for all the children with enough left over for a very tall Christmas tree. CFM was a life saver in more ways than one.

Autumn phone dinged pulling her out of her thoughts. Reaching into the side pocket of her purse Autumn snagged the phone.

It was a text from Kamara. *Out of make-up wipes. Can you stop on the way home?*

A hand grabbed Autumn suddenly as she attempted to step off the curb and cross the street.

She tried to pull away but stopped as a truck speed past without ever tapping the brake. Autumn got a quick glimpse of long blond hair as the driver rushed by.

"Watch where you're going" said the deep voice of a stranger.

"Oh my god" Autumn said over the sound of her own heart pounding.

"You saved my life. That crazy asshole in the truck came out of nowhere. He didn't even tap the brake. He's gonna kill someone if he doesn't slow down." Autumn closed her eyes and took a calming breath. "Thank you for stopping me when you did."

The stranger stayed silent. His gaze was fixed on his own hand wrapped around Autumn's arm. He seemed to be lost in thought.

"Um hey. Are you ok Sir?" Autumn asked. "I think it's safe to let go now. I promise I will look both ways this time." she said with a smile.

"Yes." he said finally letting go. "You seem to be out of danger for now. And please call me Jack."

Autumn looked at her hero's face for the first time and almost drowned in his dark blue eyes. They were dark blue with a splash of aqua surrounding the pupil. Such a beautiful and interesting trait. Like living art.

"Jack" she said still unblinking.

She tried pull her eye away but between those stormy blue eyes, that five o'clock shadow and that full bottom lip...Wow. He was something else. The stuff fantasies were made of.

"I- um I- my name is Autumn" she stammered.

When had she developed a stutter? And when had her body started buzzing like a downed power line?

Autumn looked down to break the eye contact. She should not be objectifying this man. The good ones were always taken anyway but damn a girl could dream.

"Thank you, Jack. I have been really accident prone lately and if you hadn't grabbed me when you did, I would be a pancake right now.

"Accident prone?"

"Yeah, it's like I touched a bad luck charm or something."

"What type of bad luck? Jack asked with genuine intrigue.

"Well other than nearly becoming a skid mark right now I have almost got crushed by falling books, hit my head in my front yard and blown two tires in the past three weeks."

"Hmmm. That is strange."

" Yeah. Hopefully you've just help turn my luck around" Autumn said. "Anyway, I better get going. Thank you again Jack."

"Of course. Be safe" Jack responded.

Of course, Jack thought. Of course, she was Autumn. He was still picking his tongue up off the sidewalk. This Wayward knocked him on his ass and he could not stop staring at hers as she crossed the street.

He had decided to start his search for Autumn at the orphanage, hoping he would catch her there. He had spotted the female walking down the sidewalk in his direction. In the late afternoon light, he could see the feminine sway of her hips. They moved like waves in the ocean. He was almost hypnotized by it. The closer she came the more intranced he became. When he heard the truck engine reeving a tingle started at the back of his neck. He saw the woman's intended path and knew what would happen without intervention. Jack had to increase his speed to get to her before she stepped off the sidewalk to cross the street. He had made it just in time to grab her but when he touched her arm he felt it. The tingle had spread through his body like a shock wave. That wave was followed by a healthy dose of lust and something else. Something he would have to ignore if he was to complete this mission. And he would complete the mission for his queen, but he might need help to get it done. Jack pulled out his cell, dialed the number and waited as it rang.

"What's wrong said the concerned voice on the other end of the line.

"I need your help" Jack replied "Meet me at Base in 10 minutes."

"You got it"

After the drive home Autumn couldn't wait to shower, slip into her PJs and get some rest. All the way home she couldn't stop thinking about Jack. Those eyes would probably follow her to bed.

When she walked through the front door, she could hear the bass notes of Body by

Megan Thee Stallion coming from the bathroom. Kam was pregaming for the club tonight.

"Make up wipes. Autumn groaned.

With all the excitement she'd forgotten to stop at the store. Her friend was a social butterfly in every way. Social because she made friends easily and the butterfly part explained itself as Kamara gave her best diva walk into the living room.

"What do you think? Kamara asked. "Is it too naked or just naked enough?"

Her wavy purple hair was slicked into a high pony and matched her electric lavender heels. When a girl had features like Kam she did not hide behind hair. Not to mention the 'thick thighs save lives' that she was serving in her well fitted black and white floral romper. Kamara was beautiful.

Autumn had never felt beautiful in all of her twenty-five years. Cute, sure, but not beautiful. Her dark brown eyes were a little big for her face, but her lashes were nice and thick. As much as Autumn loved the curls that she inherited from her mom, they were the true definition of unruly. Her dark coils would never slick down. Instead, Autumn's hair was a thick cluster of tight curls that did whatever they wanted most of the time. And if anyone dared try to tame her locs with a slicked back style there would be hell to pay in the form of frizz.

"You look great. I'm so sorry Kam but I forgot to stop for makeup wipes" Autumn said heading toward her bedroom.

"No big deal. We can stop on the way. Do you need help finding something to wear?"

"No" Autumn replied with a sigh. "I'm sorry. I just don't feel like going out tonight."

"No ma'am. You said you would come out with me. No take backs. You need a night out. Come on Autumn. First round of shots is on me." Kamara said the last part in a sing song voice.

"Maybe next weekend." Autumn replied

"Didn't you tell me that last weekend? And the one before? Come dance with me."

Kam said winding her hips to the beat to what was now Have Mercy by Chloe.

"Come on Autumn. It will be so much fun besides you are too young and gorgeous to be in the house every weekend."

"I'm really tired Kam. Raincheck, ok?"

"Fine but next weekend you are coming out with me. No excuses. I'm putting you on notice Autumn West. And I will be especially hurt if you say no." Kamara made sure to stick out her bottom lip and flash puppy eyes in Autumn's direction.

Autumn took a deep breath and exhaled knowing she had no other choice. "Alright. You win. I could use a little fun after today. Just not tonight. Next weekend I'm down."

"Wait. What happened today? Was your boss mad you were late today. I told you he's not gonna fire you. I think he has a little crush on you.

"No Kam it's not that. I... I almost got run over by a truck in front of Rainbow House today."

"What? Oh my god Autumn. Are you alright? Are you hurt? Why didn't you say something?"

"Yeah, I'm fine. This guy came out of nowhere and pulled me back onto the sidewalk just in time. I guess my luck is changing."

"Yeah. Thank goodness." Kamara said as she walked over to Autumn and pulled her in for a hug.

Yeah. I'm fine. I just need to rest you know. Prepare for the adrenaline crash. Besides Adam needs me to come in early in the morning.

"Of course. I'll turn the music off so you can rest." Kamara said stepping out of the

embrace.

"Let me go change and start some tea" Kamara said.

"No. I'm fine but thanks. Go have fun."

"Autumn I am not going to leave you alone."

"Kamara, I want you to go have fun. I'll be asleep in half anyway. No need for you to stay and babysit."

"No ma'am. You can have your alone time, but I'll be in my room if you need some company. No matter how late it is okay."

"Okay Mom" Autumn responded mockingly.

Chapter Three

Jack arrived at Base to find Carver busy in the kitchen making dinner. Every member of the household liked to eat. A lot. They all took turns with the cooking, but Carver was a master in the kitchen. No one was better with a blade in the kitchen or in a fight.

Jack walked over to the large black quartz island and took a seat on one of the five bar stools.

"Smells good" Jack said.

"Thanks" Carver replied looking up from his perfectly chopped potatoes and carrots long enough to grab the olive oil and give the veggies a healthy drizzle.

"So, what do you need my help with?"

"It's about the private meeting that I had with Queen Rayvn yesterday morning. She gave me a mission."

"A solo mission?" Carver asked absently placing the veggies on a shallow pan.

"She never specified that I had to complete the mission alone and there is no way that I can now."

"Why? What's the mission?" Carver asked finally placing the vegetables in the oven. Instead of answering the question, Jack stood and headed toward the large stainless refrigerator.

"Do you want a beer?" Jack asked opening the large metallic door to retrieve two bottles. Without waiting for a reply, he handed one to Carver.

Carver accepted the bottle but did not open it. Instead, he sat his bottle on the black counter and looked at Jack expectantly.

Jack uncapped his bottle before raising it to his lips. The beer was refreshing but probably not strong enough for this conversation.

"She wants me to retrieve a Wayward for her. A female named Autumn West.

Supposedly she's in danger. The queen wants the female brought here and protected for the time being."

"That sounds easy enough for one man. This should be like a grocery pick up for you. All we do is guard the royal family and investigate Waywards. Why do you need my help?

"I can't do it alone. Not this time."

"Should we call in Lucky and the rest of the guys?"

"No."

No way would he let Lucky get close to Autumn. Lucky was always reliable in a fight, but he had a thing for petite brunettes. Of course, Lucky did stick to humans due to the Bakazi rules.

One time Jack walked in on Lucky with a pretty brunette stretched across his bed. Her hands were tied to the headboard and some kind of metal bar was attached to her ankles to keep her legs spread wide. Lucky was kneeling on the bed near her head with his junk in her face and she did not seem to mind.

"We can handle this without involving the rest of the guys but she won't be safe with me alone. Jack said before draining the rest of the bottle. "

"I found her today outside of her job. She was not paying attention to where she was walking and nearly got hit by a truck. I grabbed her just in time but when I touched her...

"What happened?

"When I touched her, I felt the pull." Jack said.

"Pull?"

"The mating pull Carver."

"Jack that's--. We can't." Carver said shaking his head. "This is not some human bar fly or club girl. She's a Wayward and she is important to our queen!"

"I know that! Shit! I know it's impossible, but I also know what I felt. The Bakazi side of

me wants to mate with this female. My body felt like it was being electrocuted when I touched her. She has no idea who or what she is and when she finds out she is not going to look at me with anything other than fear and disgust. Just like the rest of them.

"They do not all hate us" Carver said finally uncapping his bottle of beer "But if you give in to whatever this is they might. One of us mating with one of them is forbidden, Jack. You know that."

"I won't give in. I don't know why I feel the pull with her, and it does not matter anyway. All that matters is completing the mission. I can track her down, but I need you to retrieve her."

"Ok. I will help you. But if the Wayward is in danger it might be smart to have someone watch my back."

Jack did not want to see Autumn again. He might be able to fight his Bakazi side but the other half of him was a lot more aggressive. Still, Carver made a good point and Jack agreed because there was no other choice. The queen's request was law.

The elder, Vervina walked into her home office. She never spent too much time in this room only using the small writing desk to pay bills. There was a gorgeous carved mahogany bookcase along the back wall. It was filled with book. Most were over a century old.

She limped toward the bookcase and grabbed the one she needed. It was a dark purple leather-bound copy of Grimm's Fairytales. On the cover was an illustration of a living forest. Trees with scary faces beckoned the unaware to their fate within. It did not hold the collection of blood curdling fables that one would assume. These page's

held knowledge that could change one's destiny. Instead of 'Once upon a Time' this tome began with an incantation.

'Power of the shadows come forth. Find this vessel worthy and grant your power within.'

The first time Vervina had read those words aloud a bright green light had grown up from the floor and snaked its way around her body. It seemed to be examining her for the worthiness she pronounced. Once the light had coiled itself from her ankles to her neck it started to tighten its hold. The embrace grew so tight that it robbed her of oxygen. The room grew dim and just as she drew what was sure to be her last breath the green light slid down her body back into the floor and disappeared. She had been gasping for life and breath when she heard a voice calling her name. She looked toward the open doorway, but no one stood there. Again, she heard her name. The voice seemed to be coming from all around her, but she could not find the source. Finally, the book opened itself on the desk. The pages began to ruffle and again she heard the sound of her name. It was coming from the book. The incantation had worked, and the book was offering her all the power on written on its magical pages. If there had been another way, she would have perused it. Unfortunately, time was running out and she was desperate to find Autumn West.

The Wayward girl's fate was yet to be determined but she wouldn't live in the dark for much longer. Waywards were named because they chose to depart from the ways of their own kind. Walking away from the foal. The reason for walking away was not important. Some were second or even third generation Wayward by now who knew nothing of the Bakazi but were called Wayward just the same. In the case of this particular Wayward she was ignorant of her heritage because of something else. Autumn was magically spelled and hidden away from the Bakazi as a child, but the magic was running out and the time was coming for her return.

Vervina closed the book and returned it to the shelf, having memorized the spell she needed. The gold words on the purple spine ensured that no one would know that she possessed the Book of the Damned. In the wrong hands the book could cause all type of destruction. She sought only advise from beings out of her reach. If the Wayward was found by those who were presently seeking her it could be disastrous. She left her office and headed upstairs. The spell called for submersion. She ran the water and added the necessary herbs. She shed her clothes and exhaled as she entered the bath. The warm water on her skin encouraged her to continue. Once she was submerged up to her neck, she closed her eyes again and slide completely underwater. She needed to be calm to communicate telepathically. She called out to her queen in her mind.

Your highness. Vervina reached out telepathically with the help of the spell. The girl has been found. Autumn West is alive and well for now. Her powers are growing, and her ignorance is dangerous.

Vervina waited in cooling water for a reply.

Bring her to me. whispered the now familiar disembodied voice.

As you wish, Your Highness. Vervina replied.

Chapter Four

After a long week of bad luck, it was finally Friday. Not only had she managed to set off the smoke detector at home, but she also caused the same thing at work. That's the last time she let Deigo talk her into making smores no matter how puppy dog like his eyes got. Of course, the fire at home happened while trying to make coffee so maybe she should just stay out of the kitchen for a while. Or maybe she needed a vacation. Lately she couldn't focus on simple tasks without getting distracted or making a mess. These crazy dreams were happening more and now she was hearing voices. If she didn't manage to relax soon, she would need a therapist. Hopefully going out tonight with Kamara would help her unwind. Get dressed up, have some drinks and dance away the worries.

Autumn wiggled and moved her feet to the beat in her head.

"Oww!" Crash. A framed drawing one of the kids had given her would need a new frame now. While she limped over to grab her trash can her boss poked his head into her office.

"Autumn? You alright?"

"Yeah. Just practicing for tonight."

Allen's brows furrowed in confusion.

"I'm going out with a friend to do some dancing. My desk is an awful partner. Guess I'm out of practice." Autumn laughed.

"You sure you're alright?"

"Yeah, I'm good. Probably a little bruised but I'm good." Autumn said rubbing her thigh. "Hey, is it ok if I go ahead and head out?"

"Sure. I'll cover for you."

"Thanks Allen."

It had been about six months since Amber put on a pair of heels. At Rainbow House cute shoes were a quick way to twist an ankle playing tag. She preferred a comfy pair of sneakers from day to day. There was defiantly dust on her club clothes, but it would be fun to go out dancing with her bestie.

When Autumn got home Kamara was already pulling options out of her closet. She negotiated an oversized rock band t-shirt dress which Kamara insisted be paired with thigh high boots. It was never too hot to wear boots in Texas and the three-inch heels were surprisingly comfortable. To finish the look, Autumn pulled her hair back in a low loose pony to show of the ripped design at the shoulder and the boot would accentuate the rips at the thigh. Comfy and cool. She liked the look. It was no surprise that a few tendrils had escaped before she finished securing the style.

Kamara had decided on a pair of black shorts with a black lace corset covered by a black jacket. Her purple hair was down in its natural soft curly state tonight. Gorgeous as usual.

About an hour later Autumn and Kamara walked into the club.

Purple lights swirled around the first floor. Bodies swayed to the heavy bass of the music. The DJ was on a platform to the left that looked large enough for a live band. To the right a long-padded bench lined the wall with a small table and chair placed ever four feet or so for additional seating. Behind the long-padded bench was the stairway to the second floor. Straight ahead was the bar.

"I know where I'm headed first." Autumn said nodding toward the bar.

"Shots! Shots! Shots! Good idea." Kamara agreed as they both started to weave their way through the sea of people on the dance floor heading for the bar.

Two vodka shots later Autumn felt a tingle down her back as if someone had caressed her. She turned around looking for the asshole who tried to cop a feel, but no one was there. Still, she felt something.

"Autumn?" Kam called over the music. "You, ok?"

"Yeah" Autumn said toying with her necklace. "I just... It's nothing. It's just been a while since I've been out."

"Oh, ok well let's go shake the rust off." Kam grabbed Autumn's hand and headed back to the dance floor.

Three bass throbbing, waist winding, hip shaking songs later Autumn still could not shake the tingle down my back.

"I need a to get some water" Autumn said into Kamara's ear so the she could be heard over the music.

"Ok. I'll come with."

"No. You keep shakin it. I'm a big girl. Besides the cutie in the hat is checking you out. Autumn said pointing the tall cutie in a San Antonio Spurs cap. "Have fun."

Autumn just needed a moment to shake off the weird feeling. Plus, the dance floor was packed, and she had to get some air. Autumn had no idea where she was going, she just had to get away from the crowd. Absent minded she walked toward the seating area but continued past the padded bench to the staircase and headed for the club's second floor bar. The second floor provided a bird's eye view of the dance floor below. She could see Kamara slow grinding on the Spurs hat cutie. Autumn wished she could be so carefree. The tingle in her spine was spreading down her legs. And she was started to feel a bit lightheaded. Now was not the time for a panic attack. Or maybe she was having a heart attack. Autumn took one step backwards away from the rail and turned to head for a seat at the bar. Instead of a clear path Autumn hit a brick wall and stumbled backward against the rails. Her heels rolled and she braced for a humiliating fall, but the crash never came. In a blink she was pulled forward and pressed against the brick wall again. This time she felt a hand against her spine and the tingle started to spread through her body.

Autumn craned her neck up took look at the person she had run into.

His dark wavy hair fell in front of his eyes like a curtain. But beyond that wavy veil were the most seductive pair of blue eyes staring down at her. His eye seemed to glow in the club lights.

"Jack?" It was strange seeing him again. And again, she was in need of assistance. "I need to sit down." she said laying a hand on her forehead to try and stop the room from spinning.

The hand on Autumn spine pressed her even more firmly against him before sweeping her up into to cradle her in his wrather muscular arms.

"What are you doing?!" Autumn squeaked.

"Taking you some place to sit down. Are you ok?"

"I'm fine. I just got a little dizzy."

Jack took his time striding the club looking for a spot away from the crowd.

The tingles were now centered in on spot on Autumns body. This man had once again flipped a switch with his touch. *Damn he's fine* Autumn thought. Maybe she could be carefree after all.

Too quickly, Jack found a bench against the wall and sat her down gently.

I don't know if you remember but we met the other day. You saved me from being roadkill.

"Of course, I remember you. Autumn, right? I apologize for my clumsiness. Are you hurt? "No. You don't need to apologize. I was just not feeling well. *I bumped into you.* I'm the one who should apologize."

"Apology accepted. Can I get you something to drink?"

Jack had every intention of staying away from Autumn, but she had found him on the second floor of the club. She had headed straight for his location as if she felt the Pull too. But that would be impossible. Mating with any of the Bakazi was not allowed but mating with a Wayward was a huge no no. Especially this one. She was ignorant of her heritage. It would not be fair to her. Not to mention she was important to Queen

Rayvn. Still, why would she have come to the second-floor bar when there was a perfectly stocked bar on the first floor?

"I'm just drinking water." Autumn responded to Jack's offer.

"Alright" Jack said he said with a smile "I'll get you a bottle of water."

"Sure, I would like that Autumn said as she headed for one of the bar stools.

Autumn wanted to bite that bottom lip. How was she so attracted to this one man. It had been nearly a year since her last boyfriend, and she was not looking. Men were not high on her list of priorities, and none had ever made her feel like this. She wanted to dry hump this man right here on their little bench. What the hell was wrong with her?

Jack returned after a few minutes with two bottles of water and a straw. How thoughtful of him to ask for a straw she thought. Jack had been nothing but a gentleman to her. He would not be ok with her straddling his thighs until she -- No. No ma'am. Where was this coming from? He is a human being not a battery powered joystick.

"Thank you." Autumn said as he handed her a bottle along with the straw.

"So do you live around here?" Autumn asked lamely.

"No. I actually don't live in this area I'm just here on business.

"Oh, Cool. What kind of work do you do?"

"Security."

"Like a bodyguard?" That would explain the hot body.

"Something like that."

"Do you like what you do?"

"It is all I am good at."

"But do you like doing it?"

"I have never really thought about whether I like what I do. I simply do as I'm expected."

He almost looked sad as he answered.

"I'm sorry. It's not any of my business. I don't get out much to talk to people my own age. I work with kids, so I sometimes forget what's personal.

"Kids huh?"

"Yeah. I love what I do. Kids need grown-ups that will listen and look out for them. I know what it's like to not have that. It's important."

And fun I would imagine.

"Oh yeah." Autumn laughed. Those little people are crazy. We have a lot of fun.

Speaking of fun, I need to head back to my friend," Autumn said gesturing toward the dance floor below.

"The young lady with the purple hair? Jack asked. "I saw you dancing with her and it looks like she is talking with a friend of mine now. I will walk you down."

"Okay. "

Jack was glad he had back up tonight. He could introduce Autumn to Carver and let him take it from there. At least that was the plan until he had laid eyes on her tonight. Autumn looked even more beautiful than he remembered. Her brown skin glowed in club lighting. He had barely been able to take his eyes off her since he spotted her in the crowd. Jack could feel prickling along his skin, so he escaped to top floor. Carver was supposed to make his move. Ask Autumn to dance and get her to talk to him. Instead, she had headed in Jack's direction and Carver was in what looked to be an intense conversation with Autumn's friend, and she looked pissed.

Kamara was headed for the front door by the time Autumn and Jack made it to the first floor.

"Where is she going?" said Autumn "I gotta go. Nice seeing you again."

Chapter Five

"Who was that?" Autumn asked breaking the long silence.

Kamara shook her head and continued to stare at the road ahead. She had not said a word since leaving Club Lavender. Silence after a fight was out of character for Kam. She was never the silent type. She always shared her emotion. The good, the bad and the angry.

Why was she so shook by Jack's friend?

"Did he say something disgusting and weird?"

"No" came Kamara's flat reply. It was the first word she had said in nearly half an hour. Progress.

"Did he touch you or something? Gurl did he grab you? Cause we can turn around right now and go back to kick his ass!" Autumn continued speculating and getting herself worked up in the process.

"Nobody puts their nasty hands all over my friend without permission. I'll punch him in the throat, and you can kick him in the balls with your heels. If Jack tries to stop us, he can get kicked in the balls too!"

The part about kicking Carver in the balls got a tiny smile from Kamara which was good enough for Autumn. Not that she wouldn't follow through on her threats but her first priority was to make her friend feel better.

"Come on Kam. Tell me what happened."

Kamara took a deep breath and glance over at Autumn before looking back at the road again.

"We dated. " Kamara finally said "I felt - I thought I felt something for that asshole. He made it clear that I was not what he wanted. I was some exotic fantasy to check off a fucking list. Literally. He broke up with me a few days after we had sex for the first time. Well lesson learned. I'm sorry I ruined your night out, Autumn"

"What?" That was not what Autumn expected at all. Kamara had never mentioned any of this.

First of all you did not ruin my night. Second, when did you date? I thought you hadn't been in a serious relationship in years."

"I haven't been and that six two piece of shit is the reason why. I know you know me as the good time girl but the reason I haven't been in a serious relationship is Carter."

"We met at a cafe on 5th." Kamara said "I was sitting alone having tea and the best strawberry brownie in the state of Texas. It was so good that I had to close my eyes and enjoy. When I open them he was staring at me from his own table. I smiled and he smiled back. Then he walked over and asked if he could join me. Normally I would have declined but something about his eyes and that smile just pulled me in. "We talked for a long time. He told me he likes to cook. Anyway, we hit it off and he asked to take me out on a real date. Then one date led to five dates and five dates led to sex.

"Ok." Autumn managed while trying to process this new information.

"It was incredible. That man treated me like a queen. A filthy, nasty, dirty queen.

Kamara said with a giggle.

"Kamara!"

"Well he did." "Best sex I have ever had and then that morning he was gone. That no good bastard. I thought... well it doesn't matter what I thought obKamously because he didn't feel the same.

Kamara had never said anything about haKamng romantic feelings for anyone. For all her talk of hot guys and clubbing she never brought anyone home with her. Autumn had never seen Kam with anyone who wasn't a friend or coworker.

"The offer still stands, Autumn said.

"What?"

"The offer still stands. We can turn around right now and go whoop his ass. How dare he treat you like some brown skinned curiosity. You don't even have to get out of the car. I will kick him in the balls for you. You can be the look out and the getaway driver.

"Gurl. Kam replied between laughs Who would bail us out of jail if we both get locked up? Besides if I drive all the way back to club Lavender, I am defiantly getting couple licks in.

Not licks but you know punches.

Yeah Nasty I know what you meant.

And I know something else too. If that bastard is friends with Jack then Jack is probably just like him. Try to live out some kind of urban fantasy. He will never get a whiff of this good good."

Both girls erupted in laughter.

"What the fuck was that, Carver?"

"Kamara." Carver responded quietly

"I know her name. She's Autumn's friend but who is she to you. More specifically why does she hate you?"

"I spent some time with her a few summers ago. We... dated."

"Ok. What did you do? Why did she break up with you?"

"She didn't break up with me."

"Carver, after that shit show at Lavender I am not in the mood for any more bullshit."

Carver was the one to work the tracking spell to find Autumn at the club. Luckily a couple strands of Autumn's hair had been transferred to Jack's clothes the first time they met. He let Carver take the lead and they had not only walked away without Autumn, but they had managed to piss off her friend. Carver had never behaved like

this in the field. There had to be an explanation. There better be one hell of a good explanation.

"The queen has commanded that Autumn be found and safely delivered to her and you may have blown that mission over a woman. Tell me what is going on between you two. Why have you never said anything about her if she meant anything to you?"

"I had to walk away from her." Carver answered with a pained expression on his face

"Why" asked Jack

"She's Bakazi. Kamara is a Wayward like Autumn."

"What?!" Jack ground out through clenched teeth

"I had no choice but to break up with her before the feeling got stronger."

"Are you sure she is Bakazi? Did she admit this to you?"

"No she didn't admit it to me because doesn't know what she is. She healed me. While we were..."

"What?"

"It was after a sparring match with you. You landed one of your monster kicks to my back. You know that was a lucky kick, right?"

"Sure it was, Carver. Continue."

"I was distracted because I had a date with Kamara. Anyway, I hadn't completely healed when I met up with her that afternoon. Let's just say she was as excited to see me as I was to see her."

"Did you fuck her?"

"Watch your fucking mouth, Jack." Carver was in Jacks face with his knife clenched at his side in less than a second. Carver always carried a blade and no one in the squad was more deadly with an edge weapon.

Jack slowly raised his hands in the universal sign for surrender and looked Carver in the eyes.

"I am sorry brother. I meant no disrespect. I am only concerned" Jack said "I want to

understand your feelings for Kamara."

An eerily calm look crossed Carvers normally bright green eyes.

Carver took a step back and put away his weapon but maintained eye contact with Jack.

"Just drop it." Carver said before walking away.

Chapter Six

Ravyn stared at the white letters against the night mode black background on her e-reader. Reading was her nightly get away. For a few hours in the dark when the big house was quiet, she could relax and loose herself in a fictional world. And unlike her own story, this fictional one was guaranteed to have a happily ever after with a little spice along the way.

"That's my good girl" he whispered as he thrusts to the back of her throat.

Ravyn was suddenly too warm for the layers of bedding that she usually enjoyed.

"That's probably enough for tonight" she said to her empty room.

Her room was filled with beautiful furniture, but no love or joy lay within its walls.

When she was alone in the dark it felt more like a cage. Yes, there were more important things than love but the search for this particular Wayward brought with it memories that caused restless nights and dangerous thoughts.

Rayvn walked over to the handmade dresser beside the door. It was her favorite piece of furniture in the mansion. It had belonged to her mother and made Rayvn feel like she was still watching over things. Some of the drawers still smelled like her mother's perfume. She sometime spoke out loud in front of the dresser as if she were having a conversation with her mom. Traditionally the ascending queen would take the master bedroom along with whatever furnishing she wanted to keep. Rayvn had decided to keep her old bedroom. It was comforting. Her father had made the dresser a gift to Ravyn to celebrate her coronation.

Rayvn ran her hand across the top of the dresser. The wood felt smooth and cool to the touch. "I wish you were here. I have so many things I wish I could talk to you about. Am I doing the right thing with Autumn West? I cannot talk to Dad about this, you know how old fashioned he is when it comes to them." Rayvn said.

"Hello Pretty Wings" said a voice in the dark

Rayvn gasped at the unexpected greeting. The nickname always caused the need to squeeze her thighs together.

"You can't be here." Ravyn said breathlessly.

"I'm here for you." came his dark reply.

"What does that mean?"

"What would you like it to mean, love?"

Rayvn stayed silent, refusing to play his stupid guessing games. How dare he show up here after all this time. Where was he when she needed him? When she had desperately needed his protection.

"Your safety has recently come into question. I will not let anything happen to you while I can prevent it."

Years ago, she had begged the universe for this man's protection, well he was not exactly a man. But the fact remains that she needed him, and he abandoned her. She had been so stupid to trust him.

"I have around the clock guards. When could I possibly be in danger? This is more of your bullshit. I asked you once to take me away and keep me safe and you refused. Now all of a sudden you want to be a white knight. I don't believe that Mikeal."

Finally, he moved out of the shadows and Rayvn's heartbeat accelerated. Familiar almond shaped eyes glowed in the dim light. Most of the time his eyes were like dark brown cracked glass. Streaks like black branches marred the perfectly singed iris.

Right now, the cracks glowed a honey amber color. They resembled magma. He was having trouble keeping his emotions in check.

"I never claimed to be a white knight. I prefer avenging demon." he grinned.

"Your vengeance is about 15 years late."

"I should have never left you alone. I could feel your fear and hers. I did not come to you now to make excuses for my inaction. Just know that if I could have taken away

the pain with my own life I would have."

"You can't be here Mikeal. You have to leave before someone finds you in my bedroom. I can hear my father in the hall now. If he comes to check on me and finds you here---"

"I know what your Silas is capable of, and you know what I am capable of.

That's why I came to you. I wanted to talk to you first so that you understand what has to happen and why I have to be the one to make it happen.

"What are you talking about. Just tell me why you're here."

"I'm here for your father's life Rayvn. Your father has been in contact with the other side. He's been shopping for an Enforcer."

"My father wouldn't know how to make contact with the other side, and he doesn't have any enemies to assassinate anyway.

"Not all Enforcers are on the other side. You know that as well as I do. Besides your father has lots of connections as the former King of the Bakazi. Many of your people have more loyalty to him than to you, my love. Any of them would jump at the opportunity to prove their loyalty to him no matter what it meant."

Rayvn felt her stupid heart beating faster from him saying the word love. Her brain knew he didn't mean it, but she needed to get her heart under control.

"My father is the most traditional person I know. He knows the laws better than anyone I know. He would never do what you are accusing him of."

"Silas is a smart man. He wants her dead and he wants it done right."

"Her? Who are you accusing my father of trying to have killed Mikeal?"

"Autumn West.

The name dropped like a boulder and so did Rayvn's heart.

"I will not let that happen. Silas will die by my hand and no other."

"No. How would he find her? I have a guard looking for her right now. He has orders to bring Autumn safely to me."

"I don't think it would be wise to bring her here with your father. I can protect her."

"No Mikeal. Haven't you done enough to fuck up my life? Now you want to kill my father too! Just go. Forget your crazy conspiracy theory. Autumn West will be protected."

Mikeal stepped closer to Rayvn. His hand reached toward her face until a long finger tilted her chin up so that he could look into her eyes. She didn't shy away from his touch or his stare.

"Do you trust this guard that's looking for her?"

"Yes of course."

Mikeal closed the inched between them and kissed her lips. His lips brushed hers so lightly that she wasn't sure he had touched her mouth. Then the tip of his tongue poked out to caress her lips before he sealed their mouths together. His lips were warm and demanding as always. He deepened the kiss and she opened for him. After all this time she still responded to him in a flash. She had craved this warmth. If she was honest, she had craved him. She wanted more. Mikeal's hands encircled her waist to pull her body closer. The feel of his hard body reminded her of how well they fit together. His big hands slid down her hips and around to caress her backside. Rayvn whimpered under his touch. Her control was slipping. In a few minutes she would be bent over the closest flat surface with her legs spread for him.

Too quickly Mikeal pulled away from her.

"Order your guard to keep Autumn hidden until this is over. He can watch over her until I'm able to finish this. When Silas is dead, I will reclaim what belongs to me."

Mikeal took one step back before disappearing in a black mist and Rayvn knew that she was the thing he meant to reclaim.

Chapter Seven

After a quick shower Autumn slipped into her favorite PJs. No one was going to tell her that she was too old for the power puff girls. The light tank top that showcased the flying trio was thin and cool which was a necessity during a Texas summer.

Autumn adjusted the red ruffled short that complimented Blossom's red bow as she climbed into bed. They were a little junior but sometime a girl just wanted to feel girly. Jack called forward all the girly energy in her body, but she had to forget about him. Girl bros before man hoes. Kamara was her best friend, so it didn't matter that Jack gave her butterflies with the sound of his voice. So what that his eyes made her panties melt. Who cared that his lips looked soft and kissable. I will never find out how soft those full lips are, and that's fine Autumn told herself as she closed her eyes and rubbed her thighs together until she fell asleep.

Autumn opened her eyes and stared at the stars in the night sky. Beautiful. The stars seemed to be brighter and the sky darker. She sat up and rubbed her eyes. A warm breeze ruffled her curly hair. When had her bed been moved outside? She was dreaming. Autumn's full-sized bed was in a forest under the stars. No doubt this was the same forest she had dreamed of for the past month. This was however the first time she had found herself in her bed in the forest. Rustling beyond the trees caught Autumn's attention. Intrigued but not afraid Autumn swung both feet over the side of the bed to stand on the grass. She could feel the grass between her toes. How? She should not be able to feel anything in a dream.

"Hey!"

Autumn turned to the sound and frowned at the person who had emerged from the forest in front of her. What now?

Long legs encased in low slung joggers moved swiftly in her direction. He looked ready for bed to her. The closer he came the better the view. A very happy trail of

dark hair covers his lower abs. And oh what wonderful abs they are.

Damn when I dream up a man, I check all the boxes, she thought.

When he stopped in front of her Autumn finally could see his face. Blue eyes the color of the sea looked down at her own.

"Jack?"

"Autumn?"

"Wow. I'm having a sex dream about him now?" Autumn mumbled.

"Sex dream?" Jack interjected.

"Chicks before dicks. But he did save my life" Autumn continued thinking out loud.

"Who wouldn't want a real-life hero? So what if it's a desperate sex dream."

"Desperate?"

He seemed almost offended. Autumn thought. Of course, her dream Jack was the sensitive type too.

It's just a dream. she thought.

Without wasting anymore time Autumn reached up to frame his face with her hands.

The prickling of his five o'clock shadow sent tingles racing down her arms and caused her nipples to tighten under her favorite tank top.

Jack opened his mouth on a rough inhale and Autumn wasted no time accepting the invitation. She quickly rose to her tip toes and pressed her lips to his. She licked and nibbled at his full bottom lip. Sighing and moaning she let her pleasure be known.

Then with a deep moan Jack took control of the kiss. Pressing his lips roughly to hers with one hand at the base of her neck to accentuate his command. His other hand swept down the side of her breast, skimmed over her waist and came to rest on her round backside.

Autumn took this as an invitation to wrap her legs around Jack's strong waist. Her arms were tingling before but now her whole body was buzzing like a live wire. She couldn't help but shiver even though she wasn't cold. Her body had never felt

anything like this.

"Bed" Autumn demanded between warm kisses.

"Oh my fuck" Jack cursed turning to following her order.

After a couple long strides Jack turned and sat on the side of Autumn's bed. Her body was soft and warm wrapped around him.

Jack could feel the wet heat of Autumn's core pressed against his naked waist.

Stop his conscious yelled. This isn't right. But his conscious was a fucking liar. This felt all kinds of right. Jack let his finger slide underneath Autumn's red ruffled shorts. The treasure he found there would have brought him to his knees had he still been standing.

"Damn it you're wet."

Autumn startled. The sound coming from Jack sounded deep and sinister. Jack sounded like a pack a day smoker who had swallowed sand. It should not have enhanced her arousal, but it did.

Jack stood just long enough to turn and place Autumn on the bed.

Autumn laid back with her smooth brown thighs spread to welcome his touch. Jack took his time. He started his caress at her feet. Jack bowed his head to land soft kiss the inside of both ankles. Slowly his hands move up Autumn's calves followed by several those soft kisses on both calves. Jack's kisses were so soft that it felt like she was being caressed by butterflies, but his hands were rough. The opposite sensation was driving her crazy. How could she feel so much in a dream? Before she could think about it too much Jack move to her thighs.

She was arching her back and whimpering as he pumped his finger in and out and in and out. She had never been so hungry for a man's touch. He honestly was a dream lover. And there were no regrets or consequences in a dream.

She started to ride his finger. She was so close to release. So close but Jack's hands were not enough. She could be greedy in her dream, and she wanted more.

"Fuck me, Jack. Fuck me." she whispered.

Her sweet filthy mouth would damn them both if he wasn't careful. He had to put a stop to this now.

"Fuck me, Jack."

Jack kissed her neck one last time before sliding his finger out of her and standing up.

You do not know what you're asking. Jack said with a pained look on his face.

"Kipeyo, you need to wake up."

"Jack?"

"Autumn, wake up. Wake up now"

Autumn closed her eyes long enough to take a deep breath and when she opened them again, she was not in the forest. She was back in her room. The forest and her dream lover may be gone but the effects of the dream remained. Her nipples ached and her ruffled shorts were soaked. Her dreams were becoming so much more real. Autumn reached down to remove her wet shorts and reveal her throbbing sex. She closed her eyes and imagined that her hands where Jack's hands discovering her body. She glided her left hand over her stomach and up to cup her right breast. She imagined Jack's long fingers pinching her already taut nipple and rolling it between his fingers.

"Jack" she whispered.

Meanwhile, her right hand sought the wetness between her legs.

"I wish you could touch me like this."

Two of her fingers swept through the moisture and into her core. Autumn closed her eyes and pictured Jack's face as she started to move her fingers in and out mimicking the motion from her dream. In her mind he was still shirtless in those low riding boxers and now he was breathing heavy. She could see a look of hunger on Jack's face as

she continued to stroke herself closer and closer to the edge.

"Yes. Fuck me. Yes. Yes. Jack." she moaned softly.

Her mind and body yearned to make him real as she hurried toward her peak. Jack's face started to change. His blue eyes were glowing now, but Autumn was too far into her pleaser to care. Just as her orgasm crashed over her Jack started to growl, she saw a flash of his white teeth. His sharp... white.... fangs!? How the hell could she hear him and why the hell did he have fangs?

Vervina wiped the steam from the mirror and stared at her reflection. The fine lines near at the corners of her eyes were a reminder that she was starting to age. Her dark brown skin no longer glowed with youth. Bakazi were not immortal. Most lived about three hundred years. Vervina was over two hundred years old. She never had a husband or children. The Bakazi race was her family. They were all her children to love and protect no matter the cost. The right decision was not always the easiest for everyone, but she would always do right by her people.

So, when she was approached with the chance to correct past mistakes that would harm the Bakazi she agreed. Six months ago she was approached while taking a hike in the woods. At first, she was hesitant. How could any good come from consorting with the enemy. But after a few meetings she was convinced.

Vervina dried off but didn't bother with clothes after her shower. She opened the door that connected the bathroom to her bedroom. The lights were dim, but she could make out his slender form laying on the bed waiting for her. His long violet robes were parted to reveal his naked chest.

"Hello Your Highness" Vervina said.

Silas insisted on formality even in the bedroom.

"Vervina you look lovely. Come." Silas said holding out a hand in invitation.

Vervina complied. Silas was the King of the Bakazi for fifty years. He loved the people as much as she did. It was an honor to share her body with him. There would be time to discuss their plans for the Wayward later.

Chapter Eight

Autumn had been distracted all week. She couldn't get that dream out of her head. She thought about talking to Kamara about it more than once this week but changed her mind every time. It wasn't so much the dream that bothered her as what happened after she woke up. At least she thought she was awake. But if she was awake, how could she possibly have heard Jack? How did she see him so vividly. Why would Jack have fangs? It couldn't be real. A person would have to be a superhero or some type of mutant and neither of those things were real. She needed to get Jack out of her head. He was driving her nuts.

"Miss Autumn. said a familiar little voice at her office door. We made something for you." said a familiar little voice.

"You did? Come over here, Millie. Let me see."

The little girl skipped over to Autumn and held out a piece of paper.

"This is you and this is me and Diego." Millie said pointing to the figures on the page.

"Woow! This is great. Did you draw this yourself?"

"No Miss Autumn. Diego drew it because he's a really good drawer. He let me color it in though."

"Cause you're so good at coloring."

"Yeah." Millie boasted with a big smile.

"Well, you know I love pictures from my kiddos. Thank you."

"Present always make me happy" Millie continued "and I wanted you to be happy instead of sad when you find out that me and Diego are leaving".

"Leaving?"

"We got adopted so we have to leave here Miss. Autumn."

Adoptions were emotional every time. She tried to bond with all the children at

Rainbow House which made them all special to her.

"Oh Millie. I'm certainly going to miss you both, but this is wonderful news. You and Diego get to have a new home with a Mommy and a Daddy and maybe even a pet."

"Miss. Autumn."

"Yes Millie?"

"Your eyes are watery."

"Oh." Autumn said dabbing at her wet eyes. "These are happy tears sweet girl."

Millie gave her a small sympathetic smile.

"Why don't you go play, sweetheart. I'm so excited and happy for you both. I'll find you and Diego before I leave today for some big hugs okay."

"Okay." Millie agreed before wrapping her arms around Autumn's waist for a quick hug. "See you later."

Autumn was happy for Millie and Diego. They deserved a happily ever after, but it was always hard to say goodbye to her kids.

Autumn reached up to bat away more tears. Her emotions were all over the place lately. She needed to relax.

Autumn picked up the phone and dialed her best friend.

"Hey Autumn. What's up?"

"I was thinking. Why don't we have a girl's night in tonight. No boys allowed. Except maybe Winston Duke or Ryan Reynolds."

"Those men are fine." Kamara said.

"And safe. Winston and Ryan would never break our hearts or date us to fulfill some kind of stupid fantasy."

"Assholes. Jack and Carver not Winston and Ryan" Kamar clarified.

"I know. I will stop on the way home for drinks and snacks. You grab the creams, lotions and potions."

"Potions?"

"Yeah girl. Depending on how drunk we get I may want to turn Jack and Carver into toads."

They both laughed before saying bye.

After work Autumn stopped at Henry's Corner Market to get gas and snacks on her way home. After the craziness at Lavender she wanted to spend some girl time with Kamara this weekend. Nothing says "girl fuck that man" like wine and snacks and a Tyler Perry movie marathon. Of course, a few hours of yelling "kick his ass" at Winston Duke or Ryan Reynolds might also make us feel pretty good.

"Thank you" Autumn said to the gentleman who was holding the door for her as he entered the store. The smell of nacho cheese and hot dogs tickled her nose. "Hey Henry" she smiled to the cashier. Henry always worked the night shift. As usual he had his nose in a biology book. "How's school?" Autumn inquired heading for the snacks.

"It's challenging. Becoming a vampire is not as easy as Stocker made it seem." Henry replied.

"What?" Autumn asked as the front door chimed and two customers walked in. One headed toward Henry at the checkout counter.

"Becoming a vampire. You know. A phlebotomist" Henry said with a smile before turning away from Autumn to greet his customer.

"Oh. Right" Autumn said as she stopped in front of her guilty pleasure. Gummy bears where her go to for comfort food. She grabbed the green bag with the trees and six

colorful bears on the front. "Sweet gummy bliss." she whispered to herself and headed for the back corner of the store.

Henry's kept non-alcoholic beverages in reach-in coolers along the left and back walls. But in the corner between the rows of reach-ins was Autumn's destination. It was a walk-in cooler where the beer and wine were stored. After the past couple of weeks, she deserved a glass of wine. The front door chimed as Autumn opened the door to the walk in.

"Now what color wine goes with gummy bears?" she asked herself since no one else was around. A pink wine with a with black and gold lettering on a off white label grabbed her attention.

"Autumn."

Autumn turned around to find the source. First Rainbow house, then the club now in a gas station's walk-in cooler.

"Jack" she said with a frown and a slightly suspicious gaze. What are you doing here? I know you don't live around here so...

"No. I just- I have to talk to you."

"About what?" she said sounding more irritated than she intended.

"Autumn, you need to come with me right now" Jack replied.

"What." "Umm no. How's your friend Carver?"

"Autumn-"

Kamara told me everything. Are you stalking me so you can do the same thing to

me?"

"Stalking you? No, I am not stalking you. I just really need you to come with me right now."

"Why?" Autumn inquired as she grabbed the bottle of Rose. The cute ones are always crazy. she thought.

"This place is not safe for you" Jack continued.

"Yeah, I'm starting to realize that." Autumn replied clutching the neck of the bottle like a baseball bat.

"EVERYBODY DOWN!!"

Two tall young men were holding very large guns near the front of the store. Both had a long blond braid and white markings on their faces. They didn't need the guns to look scary.

Someone started to scream near the cash register.

"QUIET!" scary guy number one said.

"Oh my god" Autumn whispered.

"We have to go now!" Jack ground out through clenched teeth.

"I know she came in here." said scary guy number two.

Autumn was having trouble comprehending how bad her luck had gotten. A robbery?

"Go where? We're trapped in here." Autumn look toward the frosted glass door. That is the only way out of this room.

Jack wasted no time.

He grabbed Autumn's hand and pulled her in flat against him. "That is not the only way. I will keep you safe" he said.

"What about the other people? Autumn asked.

"Those two are Kivuli. They won't hurt those people. They're looking for you Autumn "

Jack replied in a hushed monotone.

Jack's big body seemed to surround Autumn in all directions. She could hear Jack's heartbeat. The rhythmic thump was somehow calming in the chaos.

An ice-cold breeze with a familiar scent surrounded them. It was as if the air was a living entity.

The thumping in Jack's chest was slowing down. How could he be so calm? They were in the middle of a robbery.

"Take a deep breath", Jack said.

Autumn did as she was told and before she could exhale, they were no longer in the walk-in cooler of the corner store. She was still tucked against Jack's chest. His arms were still wrapped tightly around her but now she was outside. She could smell the grass. Then Jack opened his arms to let her out of his embrace and quickly turned his back.

Autumn looked around. The stars twinkled above them. Crickets chirped all around

them. They were outside now.

"How?" Autumn said between shallow, raged breaths.

"Jack? What was-- how did we..."

"Jack?" Autumn said again and started to walk around to his face.

Jack kept his eyes closed. His face was scrunched up as if he was in pain.

"Jack?" she reached out to touch his face.

His eyes slowly open and for a split second there seems to be a glow coming from underneath his long lashes but then it was gone.

"Am I dreaming?"

Jack looked into Autumn's dark brown eyes. Her eyebrows drawn together. She looked concerned for him. No one other than his Squad had shown concern for him in a very long time. Tingles were dancing along his jaw and neck where Autumn's hand had come to rest.

"Stop touching me." Jack said roughly.

"Please." he added.

"Sorry." Autumn said dropping both hands to her sides. "I was just concerned. What you did...whatever you did just now to get us out of there, did it hurt you?"

"Flying does not hurt me" Jack replied as he took two steps back.

"Flying?" asked Autumn.

"Yes. It's like teleporting for Bakazi.

"Bakazi?"

"Not now. We need to get out of the open to a safe place. Those... people at the corner store where there for you. If they find us, they will try to kill you. I think they may have tried before. I need you to trust me, Autumn. I'll answer all of your questions, but we need to move.

This is not how Jack imagined this night would turn out. He had tried to get to Autumn long before the Shadowen. Unfortunately, that had not happened. It did however confirm that the Shadowen were after her. Autumn West was not safe in this world anymore. She needed the protection of the Bakazi.

We followed an overgrown path into the woods for about half a mile. The path ended at a thick grove of trees. Jack walked over to one of the trees crouched down and placed his hand on the trunk before whispering a few words. A line of trees started to move to the side like a camouflaged sliding gate revealing a small cottage. The front porch was raised about three feet off the ground and encompassed the entire front of the building. The arched windows and doorways reminded me of a dollhouse. Scalloped cedar shingles helps camouflage the rooftop just like the front gate.

"Come" Jack said headed toward the cottage.

Autumn followed his command and walked up the steps behind him.

Jack put in a code on the keypad next to the entry way and after a soft click he opened the door.

"Is this where you live?" Autumn asked reaching up to hold the gold ring on the silver chain around her neck.

"No" Jack replied without looking back "This is a safe house."

"Safe house? As in witness protection? Why would anyone want to hurt me? I'm no one important."

"Inside" Jack said sounding like his patience was running out. Jack stepped to the side to give Autumn a clear path.

Autumns eyebrows popped up at the rough command.

"Please." Jack added motioning Autumn to go ahead of him.

After a few seconds looking into Jacks blue eyes Autumn took a deep breath and walked forward.

As she crossed over the threshold, she had the feeling that everything was about to change.

Chapter Nine

After locking the door behind them Jack hit the light switch. The cottage was sparsely decorated. The floral couch and matching loveseat form an L shape in front of the stone fireplace.

You can sit anywhere Jack said as he disappeared down a hallway followed by the sound of a door opening and closing.

"Can I have some water please?" Autumn asked breaking the uncomfortable silence. Jack appeared from the hallway.

Water? Jack inquired.

"Yes Please"

Jack walked into the open kitchen area and opened the fridge to retrieve two bottles of cold water. Jack crossed the short distance to where Autumn stood next the couch and offered her a frosty plastic bottle.

"Thank you" said Autumn "I need you to tell me what is going on."

"Ok. I'll explain everything to you. Sit down" Jack said gesturing toward the couch.

Autumn sat down on the couch and twisted the top of her bottle to open it. She took two short sips then looked up at Jack expectantly.

Jack chose to sit on the loveseat and Autumn was unexplainably disappointed that he hadn't chose to share the couch with her.

"We are Bakazi" Jack started "What you might call fae. Most people are familiar with the Celtic fae folk of Ireland, but the Bakazi are from Central Africa.

Autumn's eyebrow popped up. " Central Africa?" she asked.

"Yes"

"You're white."

"There are millions of Africans who look like me Autumn."

Of course, Autumn knew this. It was a dumb thing to say but she was in shock and

disbelief. This was the real world and magic was not real.

"I know. I just... This is all so crazy. I'm still trying to comprehend how we got out of that corner store."

"We flew" Jack said. "We do not have wings or anything. Mostly we are just people with special gifts."

"If I'm like you, what is my special gift."

"All Bakazi can fly and control the four elements-water, fire, earth and wind. In addition, some have another supernatural gift. I think you are a dream walker. After we talked at Club Lavender you came to me in a dream. Do you remember it?"

"Oh my god."

"Your gift is telepathy and dream walking is a form of telepathy. You can enter a person's mind while they are awake or while they sleep. It is a very powerful gift."

"I tried to have sex with you."

"Yes".

"I'm sorry."

"Why are you sorry? I will never be sorry for that night. It is alright Autumn. Your powers new and growing fast but there are people who can teach you to control your gift.

"Gift? Is that what I'm supposed to call this?"

"All Bakazi have powers that are meant to assist nature and our people. It is how we have survived for thousands of years. Yes, these are gifts."

"How can invading someone private thoughts help them in any way? Autumn asked.

"There are three types of Bakazi. The Seekers can see future events. The Tari have the power to heal. You are a Siliana."

Your gift of telepathy means that you have the power to communicate with anyone and anything in nature. Though it is rare to dream walk, it has happened with some Siliana in the past.

I will take you to meet the Queen tomorrow. She is the one who request you be brought here. She will help you learn to control your gift.

"This is crazy. I'm supposed to believe I'm some magical dream fairy? Even if I do believe you, why did my mother never tell me anything about this? Why would your queen want to meet me?"

"Not fairy, Bakazi. The queen requested that you be brought to her. Her request is law. We do not question it."

"What type of Bakazi are you?"

I am mostly Hali. Jack held his hand out and curled it into a fist. A fist that started to glow and was becoming engulfed in flames.

Autumn's mouth feel open.

Jack unclenched his fist and made a throwing motion toward he stone fireplace. With a woosh the previously untouched logs started to burn.

Is that enough proof or should I keep preforming ridiculous tricks?

"How did you... How.. How is any of this real?"

"I will explain but first let me feed you."

"My stomach is still doing flips."

I will cook chicken and rice for me and rice soup for you to settle your stomach. While we eat I will tell you about the Bakazi.

"Thank you."

A fairy? Autumn thought. A fucking fairy. No way. This is real life not some cartoon. Fairies aren't real. Magic is just for kids. Right? There had to be a rational, non-fairy reason for her dream. But books and Dr. Google had not been able to explain what

was happening with these dreams. Why did they seem so real. Why had she still been able to hear and see Jack after waking up that night?

Autumn looked at Jack's mouth as he bit into his chicken. Surely, she couldn't be seeing what she thought she was seeing. Her eyes were tired.

Jack put his fork down and took a deep breath.

"Yes." Jack said.

"What?" Autumn managed tearing her gaze away from his lips to look him in the eye.

"You're wondering if I really have fangs." Jack replied, "The answer is yes."

Autumn sat speechless. In one night, she had been caught in a robbery, teleported, stashed in a safe house with a strange man and now he has fangs. Autumn stood up so fast that she knocked over her chair. As she started to back away her foot got caught on the dining chair. Instead of making a dash for the door Autumn fell to the floor with a squeak twisting her knee in the process.

"Autumn. There is no reason for you to be afraid of me. I would sooner rip my fangs out of my mouth than hurt you."

Jack offered his open hand to Autumn to help her off the floor.

She shook her head and started to slide her body toward the couch.

"I do not need your help you vampire."

"Autumn. That hurt. I'm not any more a vampire than you are. Vampires need blood to survive. I merely enjoy the taste. It's like French chocolate or an expensive glass of wine." said Jack.

"Blood is a delicacy." he continued while watching Autumn pull herself off the floor and onto the couch.

"Am I supposed to just trust you? I barely even know you."

"I did save your life. Twice."

Jack sat on the couch giving Autumn as much space as he could. She was obviously

in pain, and he wanted to take that from her if she would let him.

The cabin was stocked with several herbal remedies for pain and injury. He could run her a bath with lavender and rub her injured leg with rosemary oil. He would bet her legs were soft and warm. He could massage the oil up to her thighs then ease them apart and taste her. Shit. Rubbing oil on Autumn was not a good idea.

"Maybe that was part of some game you're playing. You think it's fun to play with your food or something. "What's keeping you from gorging yourself on my chocolate blood?"

Jack's eyes seemed to change color again and a low growl started to come from his direction.

"Jack?" Autumn gasped recalling when she'd heard the sound before.

Jake moved closer his now blue eyes where focused on her like a wolf stalking its prey. Autumn knew it would be smart to escape the predator in front of her, but she couldn't. Her brain was telling her feet to move but her feet were not listening. Not only were her feet not listening but the closer Jake moved to her the warmer her entire body felt. All Autumn could do was stare into those hypnotic eyes. Eyes that seemed to be glowing as he leaned closer. His eyes now resembled shattered glasses with wisps of black skating threw the mesmerizing blue surface.

This is insane. He has fangs, glowing eyes and he is growling at me. Why am I not peeing my pants?

Then to her surprise she growled back.

Jack was on her in the next second.

His lips were soft but demanding on Autumn's mouth. Her body responded immediately just like in her dream.

Hands reached out touch her thighs and Autumn opened herself to him. Autumn groaned her displeasure as Jack move lips away. A second later she felt his warm mouth and silky tongue caressing her neck.

Would he bite her? Would she like it?

Autumn felt a sensation similar to butterflies in her chest just before she produced another growl. *What the hell?*

Jack's head snapped up at the sound and there where those glowing cracked glass eyes again. He stared into her eyes as if he wasn't sure if she was and equal or prey. He cocked his head to the side as if he had received his answer. He struck quicky like any smart predator. Before Autumn could blink Jack's hand was around her throat. Not squeezing but forcing her onto the couch underneath him.

Jack's fingers tugged at the waistband of Autumn's pants. *Holy fuck.* This was hotter than her dream. Her dream that was real because she made it real with her fairy magic.

Is that what was happening now?

Oh no. She was doing it again.

Autumn pushed forcefully against Jacks shoulders twisting and squirming until she fell off the couch and onto the floor.

"Stop." she panted to herself. "Stop. Autumn threw her forearm over her face and hoped she could disappear. "I'm sorry. Oh god I'm so sorry. I didn't mean to." she said still sprawled on the floor.

"I know. It's ok. I should not have kissed you. I was not thinking straight. We need to work on controlling your powers.

"My powers? But I'm not asleep. Am I?"

"We are awake but remember dreamwalking is a type of telepathy. You took over my mind for few minutes."

"I am so sorry Jack. I would never want to force you or anyone else to do something they don't want to do. I don't want this stupid magic."

"It's not your fault. Your powers are growing but not advanced yet."

"I let you into my mind because I wanted to. I wanted what you were offering. I still do

but we cannot.

"Your blood is forbidden to me" Jack responded.

"Why?"

"You are Bakazi. There are rules. I would never be permitted to touch you in such a way.

"If we are both Bakazi why would I be forbidden to touch?"

"You are pure Bakazi. I am not. My blood is mixed. Ones like me are called Spawn."

He said the words with such shame.

"Spawn?"

"Many years ago, several Bakazi females were taken by the Incubus. They were made to breed with them in order to produce a new race. Children like me. When Queen Olive found out where the females were being kept, she sent the royal army to rescue her people. The royal army with all their honor and tradition where like lambs against the Incubus. The queen's army was decimated. Some of the Bakazi females were able to escape with their young. Others remained trapped and are presumed dead. No one knew what to do with the unwanted offspring that resulted from the forced unions. Many of the mothers understandably wanted nothing to do with the monsters they were forced to birth. There are stories that some of the females took their young and left the Hill Country because they knew the young would never be accepted by Bakazi or safe from the Incubus. The hand full of soldiers who made it out alive delivered any unclaimed young to Queen Olive. She decided to take us in.

"She adopted you all?"

"No. We were raised to be warriors. The royal army had lost most of its fighter. The monarchy was left gravely unprotected. They had to rely on witches for protection until we came of age.

The Bakazi people would never have accepted us as one of them, but the Queen could not bear to kill us. Instead, rules were put in place. It is forbidden for any of the

Spawn to lay with a Bakazi I can never take a wife or father a child.

"You are safe with me, *Kipeyo*."

Chapter Ten

Standing under the warm spray of the shower Autumn's head was spinning. Jack had told her all about the Bakazi. She had seen the magic for herself, and she still couldn't believe it. Where both her parent's fairies or was she only half. Maybe that's why her father was not around. Maybe he was living with the fairies while her mother struggled to feed them both in the human world. But why hadn't her mother ever said anything. Surely, she knew these powers manifest at some point.

The cloud of steam in the tiny bathroom shook Autumn out of her thoughts.

She turned the water off and slide the glass door to the side to step out of the tub/shower combo.

Jack had given her a t-shirt and shorts to sleep in. They obviously belonged to him. The shirt fell just above her knee and even with the drawstring fully engaged the shorts kept sliding down. She decided to ditch those as soon as she made it to the guest room.

Rain fell on the Autumn's face as she lay in the soft grass. It felt good, like a cool spray from the sprinklers on a warm day. Frogs were croaking what had to be a happy song. Autumn closed her eyes to enjoy the sound for a minute before sitting up.

Another dream. Hopefully a pleasant one.

The purple flowers surrounding her in the field moved and swayed under weather. As with most dreams one minute you're doing one thing and the next you're driving a car.

With no idea how she got in her car she relaxed and let this dream shift play out. She recognized the route she had taken many times. She was headed home. The rain was getting harder but not too hard to see where she was going.

Just as she started to cross Webb Creek there was a loud bang and the steering

wheel jerked to the right. On a reaction Autumn pulled to left. Over correcting made things worse. Thank goodness she didn't end up in the creek. The guard rail stopped the Honda's forward progress. But the sudden stopped caused her head to bang the driver side window and then everything went black.

Autumn's eyes opened wide, and she gasped as cool water swirled around her legs. Oh god she had run off the road and ended up in the Creek. Out of habit Autumn reached for the gold ring that hung from the silver chain around her neck, but it wasn't there. Looking around the car she noticed her black interior was now peanut butter colored. Her Honda hatchback had morphed into a two-door coupe that was familiar and terrifying. This is how she died. This is the accident that killed her mother. This was another dream shift.

Autumn looked around the car hoping to catch a glimpse of the mother she longed for but she was not there. The car was nearly submerged and even though you can't die in a dream Autumn didn't want to replay the worst hour of her life.

She tugged at the safety belt but of course it was stuck. A knife she thought. Mom kept her folding knife in the center console. She pressed the release lever and thankfully the top popped open. There it was right next to the empty ____CD case. That CD had gotten stuck in the player a long time ago. A quick smile crossed her lips as she thought back to her mom singing like a pop star while she drove on road trips.

The water began to rise even more as the rain got harder. Autumn grabbed the knife and flipped it open. The blade cut through the seat belt quickly and with ease and Autumn was almost home free. Now she had to break the window to free herself completely and hopefully wake up.

A loud knock interrupted her thoughts as she was about to hit the window. That's not

what happened she thought. The banging got louder and she whipped her head around in search of the sound.

"Ma'am?" Knock "Ma'am" Knock Knock. You alright?

Is she ok came a second voice

Wake up Autumn thought.

"I think she's unconscious."

"Is she hurt?"

Wake up

"Ma'am."

Wake up.

Autumn gasped and jolted up in her seat.

Oh thank god. She's awake.

"Ma'am are you alright?"

"I'm okay" Autumn responded but as she looked in the direction a tall thin figure stood unmoving outside her car door. The figure was covered in a long hooded that left no clue to their identity.

"Hello" Autumn said as she exited the car. So much of this reminded her of her mother. Maybe she would have a chance to see her after all.

The figure turned at an inhuman speed and grabbed Autumn by the throat.

"Abomination!" Yelled a distorted voice and that when Autumn noticed the knife in his hand.

No. Stop! She screamed striking out at him with the folding knife she didn't realize she was still holding. Suddenly this dream felt very real, and Autumn was in a fight for her life. She screamed and punched.

An unseen force pinned her wrists to the car door behind her and there was no way to escape.

"Noooo! Get off me."

"Autumn. Listen damn it. You have to wake up. Open your eyes."

On command Autumn's eyes flew open wide. Jack's worried face floated above hers.

His hands held her wrists beside her head against the mattress.

"Jack!" she cried. Her voice sounded like a prayer to her own ears.

"Yes. I'm here. Are you ok?" Jack replied slowly releasing his grip. "I heard you screaming."

"When I got through the door, I realized you were fighting a nightmare."

Jack let go of Autumn's wrists and sat back on the bed giving her room to breathe.

Autumn didn't want space. She threw her arms around his neck as tears of relief ran down her cheeks. She had not known him very long but, she knew he was a safe place. She knew she was safe in his arms.

"I was so scared, she whispered nuzzling between his neck and shoulders. The closer she got to him the closer she wanted to be. He smelled like he had just taken a shower but there was something else underneath. She had smelled it back at the corner store. He smelled like the ocean. His scent drew her in until she found herself nuzzling his neck.

A prickling feeling started just below her knees, and she realized that somehow, she had managed to scissor Jack's torso with her bare legs. She nuzzled closer.

The tingle worked its way up Autumn's thighs as she started to press her body against Jack's naked side.

"*Kipeyo*?" Jack said easing Autumn's head off his shoulder to look at her face.

"You are not wearing panties."

"They were dirty."

"Autumn."

"You smell good. When I touch you, my body vibrates. I'm drawn to you. I want you more than I remember wanting any other man."

"Don't mention other men to me right now. It makes me want to mark you as mine."

"How would you mark me?" Even as she asked, she knew the answer wouldn't matter. A primal part of her wanted to be marked by Jack and she wanted to mark him in return. She wanted his hand on her. She wanted his mouth on her. It was all she could do to not rub herself against his crotch like a cat in heat.

"Show me" Autumn said.

In the span of a second Jack was on her. Thrusting his tongue into her mouth and pinning her to the mattress with his powerful upper body. She was surrounded by him. She couldn't draw a breath with inhaling him. Autumn arched her body trying to get even closer.

Jack pulled back to look at Autumn's face. His blue eyes look like cracked glass and were glowing down at her. The look on his face was close to a sneer. His other side was close to escape, and she wanted to break his control. Autumn repositioned herself so she could raise her face close to Jack's. When she was close enough, she took his full bottom lip between her teeth. When she let go she looked into his glowing eyes and growled. And just like that the beast was of its leash.

"Shirt off." he demanded rising to his full height.

Autumn scrambled to her knees and obliged.

Jack's pants disappeared faster than she could register. Everything about him was oversized. His biceps twitched. His wide smooth chest pumped up and down to the rhythm of his rapid breaths. Autumn's gaze wondered lower searching for that happy of trails that she liked so much but it seemed to be hidden behind the most perfect penis she had ever seen. Not that she had seen a lot of them. But of the three she had seen in person this one got first place. She couldn't take her eyes off it as she started to crawl to the edge of the bed. Autumn's steady hand reached out to catch a bead of moisture that clung to the swollen head. She brought the treasure to her mouth and sucked her finger with a soft moan.

Jack's control broke.

He flipped Autumn onto her back with her head at the edge of the bed.

"Open" came Jack's distorted voice.

Autumn knew he was out of control, but she wanted it. She wanted him just this way. She opened her mouth, Jack guided himself inside and she clamped her lips around him. As his hips moved slowly back and forth, he reached for Autumn's soft breasts. The feel of his rough palms and the sensation of him moving in her throat was more than enough to set her off like a rocket. Her body bowed up off the mattress and she moaned around Jack's member, but he was not done.

Jack stepped back and walked to the side of the bed. The mattress dipped under his weight.

"On your knees" he said.

Autumn rolled over and rose to all fours. She was more than ready to have him inside her. But instead of that swollen head she felt a slick tongue between her legs.

Jack was on his back with his head between her thighs making a meal out of her. He feasted on her body. Autumn started to wiggle against his mouth. She cried out.

Greed and overstimulated at once. Jack hooked around her naked thighs making it impossible to move no matter how sensitive she became.

"Jack" she screamed as a second orgasm crashed over her.

He moaned and drank down her pleasure but did not stop.

"Oh god Jack". she panted "Inside."

Jack continued to lick and kiss. Then she felt a light scrape against her lower lips.

"Fuck" Autumn said over Jack's low growl.

He let go only long enough to move his mouth over to kiss her upper thigh. The growl grew louder as Jack punctured her thigh with his fangs and started to drink from her.

The sharp sting and the firm suction drove Autumn screaming over the edge once more.

"Jack" came a hoarse whisper.

Jack, I need you inside me. Autumn spoke into Jack's mind.

The suction stopped. Jack changed his grip on her thighs and pulled her body down his own until they were perfectly aligned.

Autumn took Jack in her hand and guided him inside her. With the multiple orgasms paving the way she had no trouble accommodating his impressive size.

Autumn sighed as Jack's hips started to move like tides on the beach. His rhythm slow and almost hypnotic at first. She closed her eyes to enjoy the ride. Jack's hands found her hips and used them to steer her toward what would certainly be another orgasm.

Autumn knew that even on top she was not in control. Her arousal climbed even higher at the thought. She wanted to be at his mercy.

Jack's hammered harder and faster into her core and Autumn met his motion with her own.

"Cum for me again " Jack ground out.

Autumn's body reacted immediately as if it belonged to him. Her eyes popped open as the orgasm took over every muscle in her body. Head thrown back, fingers clinched, and spine bowed Autumn called Jack's name over and over as she tumbled over the edge. Her core clenched around Jack triggering his own explosion. His warm essence filled Autumn and she wanted to stay with him like this for hours.

Autumn clasped onto Jack's chest with both hands to prevent him from separating. They both worked to control their rapid breathing. Her eye lids suddenly had weights attached to them.

Maybe Jack would hold her all night and keep the bad dreams away.

"Stay" Autumn whispered as she drifted off to sleep.

"I belong to you." Jack responded.

Chapter Eleven

When Autumn woke the next morning, she heard voices coming from the living room. Voices plural. Should she stay hidden in the bedroom listening to the conversation or make her presence known?

Autumn decided listening for a few minutes would be the best decision.

"I trust you, Jack." Said a female voice.

An annoying feeling close to jealousy caused Autumn's chest to tighten. Why would she be jealous. Jack was not hers. He had made it very clear that he would never be hers, not even in her stupid telepathic dreams. That wouldn't change just because they slept together.

"I belong to you" was the last thing he said to her before they both fell asleep. But what did that mean? Maybe it was like 'I am to please'? No need to read too much into it. It was simply a nice response to someone asking to cuddle.

"Thank you," Jack replied "but are you sure I am the best person for this job?"

"Jack there is no one else that I would choose to watch over Autumn. You're well trained, compassionate and disciplined. Besides, your cabin is well hidden in these woods. This will be a good place for her to learn to control her powers."

May I ask, Your Highness is everything ok? You came here with no guard, and you don't seem like yourself.

"I don't always take a guard on my morning runs. You know that. Don't worry about me. I have the others to keep me safe. You keep Autumn safe while she explores her powers. I will return for her soon."

"Yes, my Queen."

Queen? She was the one who had Autumn brought needed to meet her.

Autumn rushed out of the bedroom and down the hall.

When she turned the corner into the small living room she froze.

The woman that was speaking to Jake was absolutely beautiful. Her height was similar to Autumn's five-foot five-inch frame. Her dark green jogging set showed off her slim frame. Her dark red hair was in two French braids that draped over her shoulders to rest on her chest. The woman swiped at a piece of curly hair that had escaped its binding. On her hand was a gold ring that matched the one around Autumn's neck.

"Mom?"

"Autumn"

"Mom?" Autumn breathed as if the wind had been knocked out of her. Her head was spinning. How could the long-gone mother she longed for be here in the same room with her now?

"How? How are you alive? Why are you here? Why did you leave me?"

"Autumn, I know you have questions and I want to explain everything to you. Come and sit down."

Autumn obeyed and took a seat on the floral couch next to her mom.

"All I wanted was for you to be safe. Everything that we did was to keep you safe."

"Safe from what?"

"From the Incubus and Cambion. They are dark powerful beings who want to either end our line or convert us."

"Jack mentioned them." Autumn said looking in Jack's direction. She had nearly forgotten he was in the room, but she wanted him close to her. The look on his face caused Autumn's gut to clench. He looked through her like a stranger in a shopping mall.

"Please excuse me your highness. Princess" he said bowing to both women before heading for the front door.

"Princess?" Autumn repeated. Now she was supposed to believe she was a fairy princess?

"Yes Autumn." her mother said as if reading her thoughts.

"You are a princess of the Bakazi. You will be queen someday."

"Why didn't you come back for me?" Autumn's head was spinning. She headed for the couch to sit down. The mother that she had longed for had been sitting on a magic throne for over a decade without so much as a post card to let Autumn know she was still breathing.

"I know you're upset but let me explain. Rayvn said taking a seat at the bar. Probably a good idea to give Autumn some space.

"We left the safety of the mansion when you were a before you were born. I couldn't risk anyone finding out about you. I had to run with you to keep us both alive. My parents kept me sheltered but I was a curious young lady. The more they tried to keep me under lock and key the more I tried to discover the so-called danger. I found the danger that my parents warned me about twenty-six years ago. I also found love.

Your father is Incubus. We were not supposed to be together but the feelings between us were like a fire meeting a tornado. I wanted to be with him more than anything in the world, but I was to be the next queen of the Bakazi. I had a responsibility to my family and my people. He and I knew what would happen if our relationship was discovered."

"What would have happened? Autumn said obviously frustrated. Jack told me its forbidden to... be with Incubus and thier offspring but he never explained what horrible consequences could occur."

"The parents and the child will either be exiled or put to death. When I left your father neither of us realized I was pregnant. When I found out I hid my pregnancy for months not knowing what I would do when you were born."

"So I'm like Jack? I'm a Spawn. This is a lot to process, Mom."

"Yes sweet girl. I gave birth to you a few weeks after leaving my family home. A friend helped me change my appearance and I ran with you as soon as I could. I disappeared hoping that everyone would think I had been kidnapped or killed. My plan worked for a while but, you came into your powers faster than I anticipated. By nine years old you were causing windstorms without realizing it. New powers are like a beacon for those who want to hurt us. I reached out to my friend again, and he helped me hide you and bind your powers. I thought I had more time to prepare you, but it was already too late. They came for us."

"Is that what happened the night you...died?"

"Yes. They came to our home. We had just come back from a trip to the grocery store. I felt them as soon as we pulled into the driveway. Magic calls to magic and they had never stopped looking for me. I backed out and tried to drive away but they followed me. They chased us down and ran us off the road. When we went into the water, my only concern was you. I removed my ring and put it in your hand. This ring," Rayvn said reaching out to touch the gold ring on the silver chain that had hung from Autumn's neck for years.

The ring is spelled to hide the wearer from magical beings. I wanted you to be protected even if the binding spell wore off. I reached into your mind and told you to go and hide until morning."

"I hid and waited for you in the forest all night." Autumn said. Recalling that night.

"I couldn't risk leading them to you. I'm so sorry sweet girl." Rayvn rose from the bar stool and took a step in Autumn's direction.

Then the world exploded around them. All chaos and smoke.

"Autumn!" Jack yelled.

The wind started to blow like a tornado had formed in the midst of all the mayhem.

A blazing hole had been opened in the kitchen. The ferocious wind caused the fire to

spread easily.

Autumn squinted through the smoke looking for her mother. The mother she had lost as a child was back and Autumn could not lose her now.

"Mom!"

She could barely hear her own screams over the howling wind. When no answer came, she ventured toward the burning kitchen where her mom had been standing a moment ago.

Autumn shrieked as a fire sizzled across her left shoulder.

Arms wrapped around Autumn's waist and pulled her to the floor.

"We have to fly." Jack said close her ear.

"No. My Mom--

"Lucky has her. They're gone. She's safe. We have to go."

Autumn nodded and tucked her body in close to Jack. She remembered to take a deep breath and the next minute she was standing in front of a large two-story house.

"Who was that at the cabin? Were they Cambion?"

"Yes. The fucking worst kind."

"What kind?"

"Enforcer demons. Fucking pit bulls for crossroads deals. When a human or magical being makes a crossroads deal Enforcers do the soul collecting."

"But I haven't made any crossroads deal. I didn't even know that was a real thing."

"They have been known to take a side job for a fee. Someone ordered a hit. Jack explained while heading inside the large house.

"Come on let's take a look at that arm."

Autumn looked at her left shoulder. The sleeve hung loose only held on by the under-arm stitching. She had been hit with a fireball. The skin still felt hot and was already

blistering. "It's fine. I want to see my mom."

"Lucky probably took her to the big house. Let me get you some pants and I will take you to her."

Autumn looked down at her bare feet. She was only wearing Jack's t-shirt. When woken up to voices at the cabin she hadn't bothered with pants.

"Okay." Autumn said.

Chapter Twelve

A man in black cargo pants and the biggest Jem and the Holograms shirt she had ever seen stood outside a set of double doors.

"I am Lucky. A healer is tending to Queen Rayvn. You can go in if you'd like Princess. Jack had mentioned Autumn's parentage to Lucky right before his cabin was destroyed.

"Autumn, she said as she started toward the double doors. "My name is Autumn."

Once Autumn had disappeared into the queen's private room Lucky turned to Jack.

"She is beautiful like her mother. Does she know that she's bound to you?"

"She is not. Not anymore."

Lucky was the most intuitive of them all. He could sense a sexual prospect as soon as they stepped in the same room. Lucky's libido radar could tell that both Jack and Autumn had been claimed. Bonded.

"A bond cannot be broken Jack. You know that. That is unless you plan to kill her or let that Enforcer get at her."

"I know how a bond works."

"Then you are going to tell her?"

"How is our queen?" Jack asked attempting to change the subject.

"The *tari* says the queen's injuries are severe. It will take more than one attempt to revive her. Apparently, she has some concussive injuries from the explosion including internal bleeding. I wish I could have gotten to her sooner. The healer will stay at the queen's bedside tonight. I got guard duty."

"Where is Carver?"

"He had some other business. That's why he sent me to make the supply delivery to you at the cabin. He might have finally caught a lead in his brother's case."

"I wish I knew how that asshole found us?"

"I don't know but Autumn and Queen Ravyn are safe for now. No one without Bakazi blood is getting past that blue stone boarder out front."

Jack knew Lucky was right. The blue stone boarder known as Llanite had stood as protection for the royal family for hundreds of years. It ran under the ground and surrounded the royal homestead. It was not by accident that the Bakazi settle in the Hill County. Llanite could only be found in the Hill Country. The blue rock called to them. Magic to magic.

"No one leaves the grounds for now. We'll all be safer here. That asshole knows we have Autumn. His next step will be to look for one of us to torture or trade for her location. Have you seen Sage?"

"She said something about a hair appointment this morning."

"Damn it. You stay here. I'll call her and Carver back to the mansion and we will meet later to form a battle plan."

Rayvn's body lay still under the quilt on the four-poster bed. A blue light glowed on her chest. Autumn watched for the rise and fall there that would signal life.

"She is resting"

Autumn turned to see a tall figure in dress pants and a button-down shirt emerging from a door that must be her mother's bathroom. His sleeves were rolled up exposing intricate tattoos on both forearms.

I am Matthew. You can call me Matt. I am a *tari* for the royals.

"*Tari* Autumn repeated. That's a healer, right?"

"Yes, I am a healer."

"Then why is she not conscious? I know I'm new to all this magic stuff but if you're a healer why haven't you healed her?"

"I can only do what the universe allows. I know that sounds very hippie dippie spiritual but that's how Bakazi magic works. We are connected to the universe. The queen sustained serious injuries. I was able to stabilize her, and I will sit with her tonight in case of an emergency."

"You mean like if her heart stops?" Autumn snapped. She was a bit surprised at the panic in her own voice. She just didn't want to lose her mom again.

"Shouldn't she be in a hospital? How will you even know if she's having a medical emergency. She's not on any monitors." She tried to sound calmer.

"The blue rock there. Matt said gesturing to her mother's chest. "It's tuned to her body. It should help with her body's natural healing. As long as it glows her heart remains strong. If the stone stops glowing that means the queen is in crisis."

"Can she here my voice? Do you think she knows I'm with her? Autumn asked/
The blue rock started to glow brighter when you walked in the room. Whoever you are the queen has strong feeling about you being near her."

"I'm Autumn. I'm her daughter."

"Daughter?" A range of emotions crossed Matts face. First shock then belief and finally pure joy.

"Welcome home. May I heal you, Princess?" he asked.

"It's Autumn and yes please. My arm is really throbbing."

Matt rubbed his hands together until a white light appear between his palms. When he placed his hands on Autumn wounded shoulder, they felt warm. It was like relaxing into a hot bath. And just like that the throbbing pain was gone.

Thank you, Autumn said.

It was my pleasure, Princess Autumn.

Autumn left her mother's room confident that Matt would keep a watchful eye. Plus, Lucky stood like a sentry at her mom's door. She was safe but someone had tried to kill Autumn and almost succeeded with her mom. She needed to find Jack and figure

out how to keep herself and those she loved safe. Jack's voice was a welcome clue to his location. Autumn walked down the stairs following the sound.

"I don't care if your braids aren't finished. You get your ass back to base now Sage or so help me I will send Lucky to pick you up." Jack said before disconnecting his call. Autumn walked toward. Arms outstretched seeking comfort.

Jack pulled her into his arms. His brain said it was a bad idea, but the bond was still in place. Her sorrow was his own. He would do literally anything to take it away from her.

"Jack what are we going to do?"

"It's going to be alright. I've called the squad back to Base. This property is protected. Everyone will be safe here while we figure out who's after you."

"Kamara! What if the Enforcer goes to my house and finds Kamara there. He'll kill her."

"Kamara is safe. Carver is bringing her here with him."

"Thank goodness." Autumn said relaxing in his arms.

"Autumn?" said a tall thin man as he walked into the living room. He had a smile on his face but the grin gave of an ominous vibe.

Jack dropped his arms and took a step away from Autumn. This would not go well.

"Your highness." Jack said in greeting.

"Orphan. Silas said returning Jack's greeting without taking his eyes off Autumn.

"I am King Silas, husband of the departed Queen Olive and father of Queen Rayvn. You look very much like your mother."

"Have we met before?" Autumn asked.

"No child I would remember meeting you. I have not doubt about that. My daughter only mentioned that she was seeking a Wayward named Autumn West. Now seeing

you in person I recognize the features of the women I love. You have your mother's eyes and your grandmother's nose."

Silas's fake smile faded as he turned to Jack.

"Does the queen know what you are trying to do orphan?"

"Your highness. I am sure that I do not understand."

"I am the one who is having trouble understanding. I know that my power is not what it once was, but I do remember our laws even as others do not."

"I am aware of the laws your highness."

Autumn watched the exchange as if it were a ping pong match.

"Hi. Kinda new to all this fairy- uh Bakazi royal family thing. Are there some rules or sacred laws that I should be made aware of? Do I need a chaperone to be with my friend?" Autumn asked trying to cut the tension.

"There is to be no mixing of the bloodlines. You are not to fraternize with those below your station. Especially his kind." said Silas.

Autumn looked to Jack as if expecting a fight to break out at any moment. Instead, Jack stood still and quiet with his head bowed as tradition commanded. Maybe Autumn would understand what he had to do now. A bond could only be broken by death, and he would not let Autumn's heart be the one to stop beating. She was innocent in this. She didn't know the consequences of a bond with him. He did the crime.

"You are excused, orphan. Go back to your quarters."

Jack began to move toward the door.

"Are you for real?"

"This is very real, Princess." Silas answered.

"Jack wait." she called hurriedly making her way to the door.

Jack kept moving as if his name had changed.

"Jack! I know you hear me. Stop. Please Jack. Talk to me."

Jack stopped at the doorway to look over his shoulder. His eye still not meeting Autumn's.

"What is it, Princess?" he asked in an even tone.

"Why do you let him treat you like that?"

"He is your grandfather and part of the royal family. As are you. I should have never overstepped with you."

"Overstepped? You mean you regret sleeping with me."

"I have to go. I'm sorry."

Chapter Thirteen

Angry tears crept down her cheeks as Autumn stormed up the stair. She would not look back no matter how much is hurt. *I will not look back. I will not look back. I will not look back.* Repeating the words like a mantra in her head was necessary to keep her dignity. Her first instinct was to fight. She needed to fight with him in order to fight for them. But why fight for someone who didn't want you. Jack didn't want to be around her. He regretted sleeping with her. It was his loss. So why did her chest feel like it had been ripped open with a plastic butter knife. Why could she not control her emotions when that fucking fairy was anywhere near her? She had been ready to fall in love with him and he just wanted to check her off his to do list.

A strong wind blew through the second-floor hallway. Autumn turned to find the source the breeze but as she rotated so did the wind. The air swirled around her, ruffling her curls.

"Autumn. Are you ok?"

The wind immediately stopped.

"Carver. Is Kamara here with you?"

"Yeah. Flying didn't agree with her. She's at Base.

"Good. I could really use my friend right now."

"Maybe we she get your emotions under control before you see Kamara. Looks like your powers are growing."

"Powers?"

"The wind. That was you, Autumn. When we loose control of our emotions, we loose control of our powers too."

"I -- I don't know how I did that. I'm not very good at this whole magic being thing.

"It's alright. Coming into your powers is a tough time especially for a Wayward. I would

be glad to show you a few things, but I'm supposed to relieve Lucky for a few hours.

What has Jack showed you?"

"Jack showed me his own powers, but I guess we haven't had time to work on my own."

"Come on" Carver said heading toward Lucky's post.

Lucky was still standing in the hall outside her mother's bedroom.

"Hey Lucky. Jack wants me to relieve you."

"Why? I told him I would take watch tonight. It's been less than an hour."

"I think you may have to do a fly by on Sage."

"Damn it. Excuse my language, Princess. Lucky said.

"Princess? Carver asked looking at Autumn with wide eyes.

"Haven't you heard? Autumn is Queen Rayvn's daughter." Lucky said with a wide smile. Taking entirely too much pleasure in dropping the princess bomb before leaving to deal with Sage.

"Please don't start acting weird. I'm just Autumn the Wayward and you were going to help me with my magic."

"Alright." Carver agreed after a long moment. I can't show you all the elements inside the mansion. We don't want to destroy the place, but I can show you wind and water. Do you know what your bonus power is?

Im *Siliana*.

"Cool. Carver said grabbing a bottle of water from a cooler on the floor. We'll practice water manipulation first. You can use this same technique to control your telepathy. Look at the water and in your mind tell it what to do. "

"Do I need to wave my hands around or point to it or something?"

"Your hands will help at first then when you get more comfortable you won't need hand motions."

Autumn worked on taming her powers for about an hour before a loud grumble noise

started to come from her stomach.

"Who knew that learning to control magical powers would work up such an appetite?" she said

"Why do you think we eat so much?" Carter laughed. I sure Jack can cook something at the house for you and Kamara.

Jack didn't want to see her tonight. Maybe ever after the way he reacted to dear ol' grandpa. Come to think of it, Jack had been doing nothing but trying to get rid of her the whole time they were together. Maybe it was a pity fuck.

"Thanks for the offer, Carver but I'm really tired. I think I'll find something here. Do you think Kamara will stop by later?"

"Yeah she wanted to come straight here but I told her to come over when she feels better. When I see her, I'll send her your way."

"Thanks. I'm on the other end of the hall."

"Hey if you want a quick snack there's always fruit in the kitchen downstairs. Make a U turn at the bottom of the stairs. You can't miss it."

Autumn found the kitchen. Of course she couldn't miss it. It was the huge. Kamara would love the white and blue stone island. She always complained that their kitchen didn't have enough counter space to spread out. This island would probably seat eight people. On the counter behind the island Autumn spotted a bowl of fruit and her stomach let out a loud growl. An apple would have to be her dinner for tonight.

Practicing magic was definitely a workout but she had to admit it was fun.

After washing her zero-calorie dinner under the kitchen faucet she took a bite not bothering to dry the fruit. This had to be her mother's touch. Her mom always made sure there were healthy snacks for Autumn to grab on the go. The memory made her smile as she headed for the stairs.

When she reached her bedroom door most of the apple was gone. Maybe she should

have grab a banana too but there was no way she was trekking back to the kitchen. Someone had laid a nightgown on her bed.

"Nice" she sighed.

She headed to the adjoining bathroom to shower and change. She had been so worried about her mom before that she'd barely had time to change clothes.

Autumn turned the knob to start the water. The warm spray felt like heaven on her skin. Not surprisingly there was shampoo, conditioner and Citrus scented body wash in the shower cubby. Normally she wouldn't dare wash her hair away from home, but her coils smelled like smoke thanks to that asshole at the cabin. Nothing was normal about the last forty-eight hours so she lathered up.

Thirty minutes later Autumn stepped out of the shower. She wrapped one soft white towel around her body and another around her hair. It would take hours to dry but she was too tired to search for a blow dryer.

There was a small bowl of berries on the nightstand by the bed. How had she missed that before getting in the shower?

"I must be really tired" she said grabbing a couple blueberries and popping them in her mouth. Tart.

Autumn opened her eyes and looked around. She must have been exhausted she didn't even remember laying on the bed. She sat up to stretch and that's when she saw it.

A person was laying on the floor near the foot of the bed.

"What? Hey are you ok? She lowered her feet to the floor and approached what seemed to be a lifeless body.

Oh shit. I'm dreaming.

The body on the ground was her.

Lucky walked into the house to the Thump Thump Thump of someone hitting the heavy bag and he could guess who it might be.

He headed straight for the gym in the back room of the house. When he arrived in the home gym Jack was covered in sweat. Fists and feet flew at the heavy bag with no signs of slowing. The temperature of the room was at least twenty degrees higher than the rest of the house. Jack's emotions were out of control. He didn't acknowledge Lucky's presence.

Lucky position himself behind the object of Jack's fury. A dangerous position for sure but his friend needed to have a conversation.

"Jack" Lucky said peering at his friend while holding the heavy bag still.

"Move."

"Jack, we need to talk."

"Move."

Jack's eyes were glowing. Dangerous but this conversation needed to happen now.

"Fine I'll talk while you continue to throw a fit."

"Fuck you"

"You need to talk to Autumn."

"Fuck off Lucky. I called you to find Sage not because I need to have a Dr. Phil moment."

"Did I hear my name?" Sage chose that moment to make her appearance.

"Where the hell have you been Sage? I called you almost an hour ago."

"I couldn't leave in the middle of my appointment." she said pointing at her fresh black and pink box braids. "I'm here now. Where's the fire?"

"Later." Lucky answered.

"You can brief her now. Somewhere else. Not here."

"Meet me in the dining room in fifteen minutes." Lucky said.

"Yes, sir." Sage responded with a grin before going to do as she was asked.

"Get the fuck out Lucky."

"She can't help who her parents are Jack. We should know that. I know what the laws say but Autumn is Wayward. Did you explain things to her before you bonded with her."

"She's the Princess!" Jack shouted striking out at the punching bag. Lucky was knocked to the ground by the explosive force. Fire was spreading from the spot on the bag where Jack had connected the punch. Flames crawled up his arms and danced across his chest.

Jack's growl rattled the windows until Lucky was afraid, they might shatter.

Lucky rose to his full height and stretched his arms wide. In a practice motion he brought his arms together in front of his body gathering air along the way. In a rush Lucky pushed the air at Jack's fire wrapped body. It was like blowing out a big pissed off birthday candle. Lucky hammered his friend with wind until it was Jack's turn to fall to the floor.

Jack lay on his back with his eyes closed. Chest pumping up and down from the exertion.

"Listen to me." Lucky said reaching down to grab Jack's hand to haul him to his feet.

"Autumn is a beautiful, powerful woman. From the small amount of time, I have spent with her I know she will make good queen one day and nothing is stopping you from being by her side."

"Why were you with Autumn?" Jack asked through gritted teeth.

"She was pretty upset when you left her at the mansion. She caused a windstorm in the upstairs hallway. She didn't realize she was controlling it. Carver's trying to show her how to use her magic now. Obviously, you know as well as I do that our powers

are tied to our emotions. " Luck motioned to the smoldering punching bag.

"The Incubus inside me wants her. It wants to possess her, mark her like an animal. This is why the law is in place. I have already made the mistake of letting things get out of hand. I have to end it now, before it's too late.

"You've bonded to her. That's not an Incubus thing. That's a Bakazi thing. The law is in place to keep our Incubus DNA out of the Bakazi gene pool but that may not apply to Autumn."

"What do you mean? She is a Bakazi princess. The law especially applies to her."

"Why was Autumn's birth kept secret? We know that her mother is Bakazi, but what do we know about her father?"

"What are ---

Jack stopped as if someone had pressed the pause button on his life.

"Jack?" Lucky waved his hand in front of Jack's suddenly vacant stare. Jack's body was still standing in the gym, but his mind had been forced somewhere else.

Chapter Fourteen

Stay calm. Autumn told herself. She closed her eyes and took several deep breaths in through the nose, out through the mouth.

Wake up.

Wake up.

Another set of deep breaths.

Wake up.

Wake up!

"Why can't I wake up?"

She looked down at her body and tried to remember what happened. The last thing she remembered was getting out of shower. What happened after that? She looked at her body wrapped in a white towel. There was a two-piece pajama set laying on the bed. Someone had put it there before she made her way to her room.

Autumn looked around the room for any sign of a fight. If someone else had been involved she would have tried to fight them off. Nothing was out of the ordinary except a bowl of fruit was on the nightstand. "Blueberries" She had eaten an apple but was still hungry when she got out of the shower. She ate a handful of blueberries.

They were bitter. Were they really blueberries or something else?

"Am I dead? I ate poison berries and now I'm...dead. I can't be dead. I just found this whole new life. No if I were dead, I would be floating away from my body or there would be a bright light or something. Right?" Autumn asked herself out loud.

She looked closely at her body this time. She had to be alive. Her back moved up and down. She was breathing but she could not just sit around and wait to be found. She didn't know how much longer her body could fight whatever poison she had been given.

If she was only unconscious and not dead, she should be able to use her telepathy and dreamwalk.

She had already seen how strong her connection was to Jack. No matter how he felt about her this was like and death.

Autumn closed her eyes and pictured his face. He was talking to someone.

"You've bonded to her. That's not an Incubus thing. That's a Bakazi thing." the person was saying.

"Jack."

"Jack, I need you."

The connection was not as strong as it had been the last time, she entered his thoughts.

"Autumn?" Jack responded.

"Yes. I need your help. I'm at the mansion in my room. My body is on the floor. I can't wake up. I think I'm dying.

It was taking so much strength to communicate.

"What?"

"I think someone poisoned me Jack. Please hurry. I'm so tired."

Hang on. I'm on my way."

Autumn hoped that Jack would be there fast enough to keep her from floating away from her body permanently.

Jack blinked his eyes as his consciousness reentered his body. Lucky was standing in front of him with a concerned look on his face.

"It was Autumn. She's *Siliana*. Someone poisoned her. We have to get to her now."

Jack ran through the house with Lucky close behind. All he could do was picture Autumn's lifeless body on the floor. He should have never left her alone.

"What's going on?" Kamara asked as both men ran past her on the front porch.

"Kamara, Autumn's hurt." Jack said without slowing his pace.

"I'm coming with you." Kamara said.

They all sprinted across the lawn to the mansion. Jack and Lucky stood side by side in front of the grand wooden door. Jack wanted to run through the damn thing like a tank but thank the universe that Lucky was thinking clearly.

Lucky entered the security code on the keypad next to the door and they all headed inside. Jack took the stairs two at a time. Autumn could be dyeing, and she was scared and all alone. Why did he leave her alone?

Jack went left when he reached the landing and ran to Autumn's door.

The scene inside was like a nightmare. Autumn was laying face down on the floor and didn't appear to be breathing.

"No no no no no no no." Jack said as he dropped to his knees and turned over Autumn's limp body.

"Autumn wake up baby." he pleaded while gathering her in his arms.

"Lucky get help!"

"I can help her." Kamara said sinking to her knees in front of Jack. "Lay her down flat on the floor."

Jack felt helpless as he watched his mate slip away forever. Kamara was saying something. She loved Autumn too. Did she feel like there were knives in her chest. Did Kamara feel like there was a vice around her throat? Is that what she was saying?

"I heard yelling. What's going on?"

Kamara's eyes darted toward the sound of another person entering the room.

"Someone poisoned the princess, Carver." Lucky said.

"Shit."

"Lay her down Jack. I can help her." Kamara repeated finally getting through to him.

Kamara started to rub her hands together above Autumn's body until a white light

appeared between her fingers.

"What is she doing?" Carver asked.

Kamara laid one glowing hand on Autumn's belly and another on her neck.

The room fell completely silent. After a few minutes Kamara started to speak softly.

She was whispering something to the universe that was between her and the creator.

The light in Kamara's hands started to spread all over Autumn's body until she was wrapped in a cocoon of white light so bright that everyone needed to shield their eyes.

A gasp came from somewhere inside the light as it started to dim. Autumn was firmly back in the land of the living.

"Thank the universe." Jack said as he pulled Autumn back into his arms.

"I should have never left you alone."

"Promise you won't do it again." said Autumn.

Two hours later Jack, Lucky, Autumn, Carver and Kamara all sat on the leather sectional at Base. Sage was stationed in the mansion outside Queen Rayvn's door. After Autumn was revived Jack insisted on a full exam by the royal tari. Matt did as thorough an exam as he could with Autumn fully clothed. Jack had nearly needed to be restrained when Matt asked her to remove the towel she was wrapped in when they found her.

They were able to agree that Autumn wear the two-piece sleep set that had been laying on the bed. That way Matt could check her abdomen. Jack sneered at Matt the entire time, but Matt kept things very professional. Once Jack was satisfied that she was healthy he picked her up and carried her out of the mansion and back to Base. Jack refused to break contact even now. He held her hand, placed his hand on her thigh or wrapped and arm around her waist while they sat on the brown leather

couch.

"Those were Pokeberries in your room. Basically, you ingested nightshade. It's a miracle you're alive right now. Thank you, Kamara." Jack said

"I'm sorry I couldn't tell you sooner Autumn. You had to find out about your heritage on your own. I was just around to help guide you and keep you safe."

"You saved my life Kamara. You're forgiven." Autumn responded with a smile. She would have hugged her friend, but Jack had a death grip on her, and she couldn't blame him.

If she had found him half dead on the floor and had him magically brought back to life, she would probably be a little clingy. She hadn't known him long but the thought of losing him made her eye sting with tears that she refused to shed.

"Carver you were on guard duty. Did you see anyone go into Autumn's room?" Jack asked.

"I saw a servant go into that room before she got there. A young woman with short brown hair. I've only met her briefly, but I think her name is April. I doubt she has a grudge against you. Someone ordered her to deliver those berries."

"April? I know her." Lucky chimed in.

"Why am I not surprised?" Carver asked rolling his eyes toward the ceiling.

She's a sweet girl. Wants to be a teacher. If she delivered those berries, it was on someone else's orders. The same someone who hired that Enforcer demon. Find that person and we find our mastermind.

"You think she'll talk?"

Jack cell rang before Lucky had a chance to answer.

"What up? I'm on my way." Jack said before disconnecting the call and turning to Autumn.

"Your mother is awake and she's asking for you."

Chapter Fifteen

Autumn and Jack headed to the Queen's bedroom while Lucky went to question April. The servants were usually in their rooms by this time of night. Lucky had been to the third-floor bedroom before to get acquainted with the young lady. There was no way she was knowingly involved with trying to hurt someone.

Lucky knocked on April's bedroom door and waited for an answer that didn't come. He knocked again. Maybe she was already asleep.

"April." he called hoping to rouse her.

A crash came from the other side of the door.

Lucky turned the knob but the door but it was locked tight. He took a couple of steps backward to give himself room. One kick and the door flew open to reveal a shocking scene.

The dowager King, Silas stared over his shoulder at Lucky's intrusion. He was holding a pillow over April's face as she struggled to keep breathing.

"Get off her Silas!" Lucky lunged for the other man grabbing him by the collar and pulling him free of April.

"It was you, wasn't it? You ordered April to take that fruit to Autumn's room."

April sat up on the bed coughing and gasping for air.

I couldn't risk the maid running her mouth.

You son of a bitch. Lucky said just before his fist shot out the connect with Silas's jaw.

Silas stumbled back from the force of the punch.

"April, get out of here. The Squad is in the queen's bedroom. Tell them what happened. I'll make sure this asshole doesn't try to get away."

April eased off the bed. She kept her eyes on Silas obviously afraid he would try to somehow finish the job that Lucky had interrupted.

"It's ok. I not gonna let him hurt you. Go."

As April walked toward the doorway Silas made his move. Lucky caught a flash metal a second before Silas sank the dagger into Lucky's side.

April screamed and ran down the hallway.

Lucky went down holding his side, but he would not let this traitor take his life. Lucky kicked out just as Silas advanced to no doubt finish him off. Silas fell hard and the dagger skittered across the wood floor.

Rayvn pulled Autumn into a hug as soon as she walked through the door.

"Thank the universe you're okay. The last thing I remember is laying on the floor watching a fireball flying toward you. I couldn't move. I couldn't save you."

"Mom I'm ok. It's not your fault that some demon tried to flambe me".

"Sweetheart I don't think you are safe here. I came to the cabin to ask Jack to keep you there longer so I could... so I could look into so accusations.

"May I ask my queen what accusations?" Jack said.

Rayvn looked at Autumn with unshead tears in her eyes.

Sit with me Autumn. Rayvn said leading Autumn toward the window seat.

I have made so many mistakes with you and I am sorry for that. I'm sorry for not putting you first over this damn throne.

Mom it's ok. Autumn answered softly. You did what you thought you had to. You tried to keep me safe from the Incubus and I know you've done the same for the Bakazi.

"The Incubus are not the only threat to you."

Knock Knock.

Sage opened the door without waiting for a response.

I'm sorry to interrupt your highness but this young woman says she has something urgent to talk to you about.

Your Highness. The royal gaurd is needed. Lucky is in my room and he's been hurt.

What? Asked Sage before giving anyone else time to respond.

Lucky saved my life. King Silas... he tried to kill me. He's in my room. You have to help him.

Stay here with the queen and princess Jack ordered.

"No." Rayvn and Autumn answerd simultaneously.

We do not have time for this. Lucky could be dieing.

"Where is Sage?"

"Damnit Sage" he called after knowing where she was headed.

He could already feel the air shifting as he jogged up the stairs. Someone had started a wind storm on the third floor.

Watch out Lucky yelled. A second later Sage and Lucky literally flew out of the room and crashed into the other side of the hall.

"Silas!" Jack yelled. There was no fucking way that was happening.
Bring me Autumn West and I will let your Squad live.

"Mikeal if you can here me I need you. You were right. Autumn needs you." Rayvn said quietly with her eyes closed. The queen was sending out a telepathic distress signal.

Good. Silas was crazed and they could use all the help they could get.

Currently Jack wanted to rush in and rip Silas' throat open with his teeth but he had to keep a level head. They were already down two people. Lucky and Sage still lay in a heap were they had crashed.

The one thing he couldn't do was let Autumn walk in that room.

"Father can I come in the room with you. I want to here your side of things."

"No Your Highness. He's out of his mind."

"He wont hurt me Jack. Just keep Autumn safe. I know you care for her. It's ok. If I had listened to my heart instead of some stale law none of this would be happening. I need to try and fix this."

"I don't like you going in there but your request is law. I can't stop you."

"Mom"

"It's going to be ok Autumn. Stay with Jack and wait for me. I love you."

Dad I'm coming in.

Dad Autumn is innocent. Why are you doing this. She's your grandchild.

"No! She's an abomination. You should have come to your mother and me. We could have gotten rid of it."

"No. Father. Autumn is a gift. She's a symbol of love."

Blasphemy. She's a stain on the royal blood line. For years the Bakazi royal family has staid pure of blood and magic. I will no argue this truth and I you can't see that then you are no daughter of mine.

"Daddy."

The movement was so quick there was no time to react.

Silas held the dagger low and plunged it into Rayvn's belly.

Rayvn gasped and fell to the floor with both hands pressed to the fresh

"Mikeal"

Rayvn groans as she falls to the floor.

"No" Silas said in disbelief.

Black mist appeared on the third-floor landing and all hell was truly about to break loose.

"Rayvn!" Mikeal yelled racing toward the lifeless body on the floor. As he drooped to the floor beside Rayvn, he let out the ear-splitting howl of an animal in mortal pain. He cradled her head in his lap and caressed her face.

Silas stood in shock like a statue. The dagger in his hand stained with Rayvn's blood.

"Daughter?" Silas said dumbfounded.

Mikeal's head snapped up at the sound of Silas's voice. The room started to shake.

No not just the room, the entire house was moving. Mikeal's shattered brown eyes glowed. The shatters traveled down his check like tears. The light fixtures in the room began to spark and explode. He swiped his hand toward the dowager king and Silas

floated up to the ceiling. His feet kicked underneath his ever-present dark robes and he started to claw at his neck as if he couldn't breathe.

Mikeal clenched his outstretched hand into a loose fist and held Silas in place ignoring his sickly chocking sounds.

Jack threw his body over Autumn to shield her from the chaos. This was a pissed off full blood Incubus. He had to protect Autumn long enough to get her out of this house.

The chaos calmed for a moment as Mikeal looked at Rayvn and began to speak.

"Do not give up Pretty Wings. Remember you belong to me body and soul. You will not leave me."

"I'm sorry. Look after our daughter. Keep her safe. I love you both."

"No! Mom!" Autumn cried reaching out for her mother.

Jake wrapped his arms around her giving as much support as he could.

Mikeal closed his eyes and lay Rayvn's head gently on the floor still holding his left hand outstretched toward Silas.

"Jack get Autumn out of here."

"Yes sir."

Jack gathered Autumn in his arms and headed for the doorway.

When his daughter was safely out of the room, he raised his other fist toward Silas.

"You took what is mine."

Mikeal began to lower his fist slowly and Silas let out a hoarse scream as his flesh slit open at the top of his head and continued down his neck like a snake losing its skin.

Before he could pass out from the pain Mikeal motioned his head to the side using his powers to snap Silas' neck and let his limp body fall to the ground.

Mikeal knelt down next to Rayvn's body and gathered her in his arms before disappearing in a cloud of black smoke.

Jake hurried down the stairs with Autumn in his arm with no destination in mind. He

only knew he had to get her away from this building.

"I knew this would happen. My love is dead because of you."

Vervina what are saying? Jack asked.

The elder raised her hand toward Autumn. That was when Jack saw the gun.

"Put me down Jack." Autumn said.

Jack followed Autumns request not because he wanted to but because he would need his hands free if he was going to stop Vervina. As soon as Autumn's feet were on the floor, he stepped in front of her.

"She killed Silas! I saw his death in a vision. I told him to try another way. He never listened to me when it came to you. You will be a plague on the Bakazi people.

"Listen to me Vervina. "Autumn did not kill Silas. He went mad and murdered his own daughter, but he was still breathing when we left the room."

"No. He would never hurt Rayvn."

"He stabbed my mother." Autumn said from her position behind Jack.

Good girl Jack thought. Stay out of sight and stay alive.

"I don't know what he told you but he's not who you think he is. Don't believe his lies.

Let me get Autumn out of here safely."

"If the Queen is dead Autumn West will take the throne with her tainted blood. I cannot trust a demon spawn lead my people. She has to die.

Jack charged at Vervina as the gun went off. Jack barley felt the sting as a bullet pierced his arm. Jack crashed into Vervina they went down hard and Vervina went still. Her eyes where frozen in a blank stare and blood started to pool around her head.

Chapter Sixteen

Autumn stared into the mirror of her mom's antique dresser. She had been told the dresser used to belong to her grandmother, Olive. She had asked Jack and Carver to move it to Base for her while the mansion was being repaired. Her father had done some "redecorating" before he ultimately killed Silas. The stress of nearly dying had brought about her transition in full force. Her curls were as unruly as ever but now had red highlights like her mom's and that wasn't the only change in her appearance. Her eyes had lightened to the same amber shade as her father's and her lips seemed fuller too. Though that may have been due to the addition of her brand-new fangs. Two days after the attack she had gone to bed with a headache and woken up forty-eight hours later with Jack and Kamara at her bedside. They explained what had happened and patiently answered her questions.

Four weeks had passed since Autumn's life had been turned upside down. She'd nearly been killed by her grandfather and his mistress but thanks to Jack and the rest of the Squad she was still on the right side of the dirt. It was hard to believe they had known each other for so little time. Meeting Jack had changed her entire life. She had gotten to spend time with her mother. Her best friend turned out to be magical and in a broken relationship with a fairy slash demon. But she knew their situation would work itself out.

Now Autumn had a group of people that she considered family. She knew they would look out for her, and she would do her best to look out for them.

Lucky and Sage saw her mother being taken away by her father, the Incubus. She was still coming to grips with the fact that she was not only a fairy but part demon too. Incubus were apparently not known to fall in love, but her mother had spoken as if they had a short-lived romance. According to Sage and Lucky her mom's body was unmoving when she was taken, but Autumn needed closure. If there was any chance

to have more time with her mother Autumn wanted it.

Lately she had been dreaming about her father. Though she had the feeling that she was not controlling those dreams. The dream was always her mom's bedroom. The location made her feel safe and she had a feeling her father knew that. The first night he had visited her dream and introduced himself as Mikeal. He said that he was devoted to my mother and me. That he would always watch over me. I asked if my mother was alive, but he would only confirm that she was with him now.

The next week he returned to my dream saying that he wanted me to ascend to the throne. That it is what my mother wanted for me. I agreed to do so temporarily. The Bakazi deserved a leader until their queen could return.

Two weeks later he made a return. I asked him again if my mother is alive. Maybe she was recuperating from her stab wound. He refused to reply saying this would be his last visit for a while. He said that he trusted Jack to watch over me for a little while but that we would see each other again.

"We will find her, *Kipeyo*."

"What?"

"Your mother. I know you are thinking of her when you stare into her mirror."

"I want to find her Jack. I need to be sure this time."

Jack wrapped his arms around her from behind and put his face next her own.

"I know. The Squad is checking all or sources. We will find her."

It felt so good to have him wrapped around her. Safe and quiet. The concerns of the world melted away when she was in his arms.

"I love you."

"And I love you, Autumn West. My partner, my mate, my princess."

Autumn smiled and turned in his arms wrapping her arms around his neck to pull him in for a kiss.

Jack deepened their kiss and slid his hands down to rest on her butt, pressing himself

even closer to her. The satin of her robe only enhanced the feel of his touch on the naked skin beneath. She moaned into his kiss and pressed her chest against his. Jack gripped her thighs and sat her on the dresser. Autumn had to spread her legs until they were nearly flat against the hardwood surface to accommodate his size. The position turned her on even more. Autumn nuzzled against his naked chest for a second before pulling him in for another kiss. This time she grazed his bottom lip with her teeth.

Autumn reached for Jack's pants. Thank the universe for an elastic waistband. Easy access.

Just a little tug and her prize sprang free. She would never get tired of the feel of him in hands. Smooth and hard at the same time. As she started to stroke him Jack growled.

Enough *Kipeyo*.

You never let me play. Autumn pouted.

We have a lifetime for you to play. Remember I belong to you and you belong to me.

Jack said. Then he sank into her and started to thrust. Autumn wrapped her legs around him pulling him as deep into her as she could.

Jack was right they would have a lifetime together because he belonged to her, and she belonged to him.

